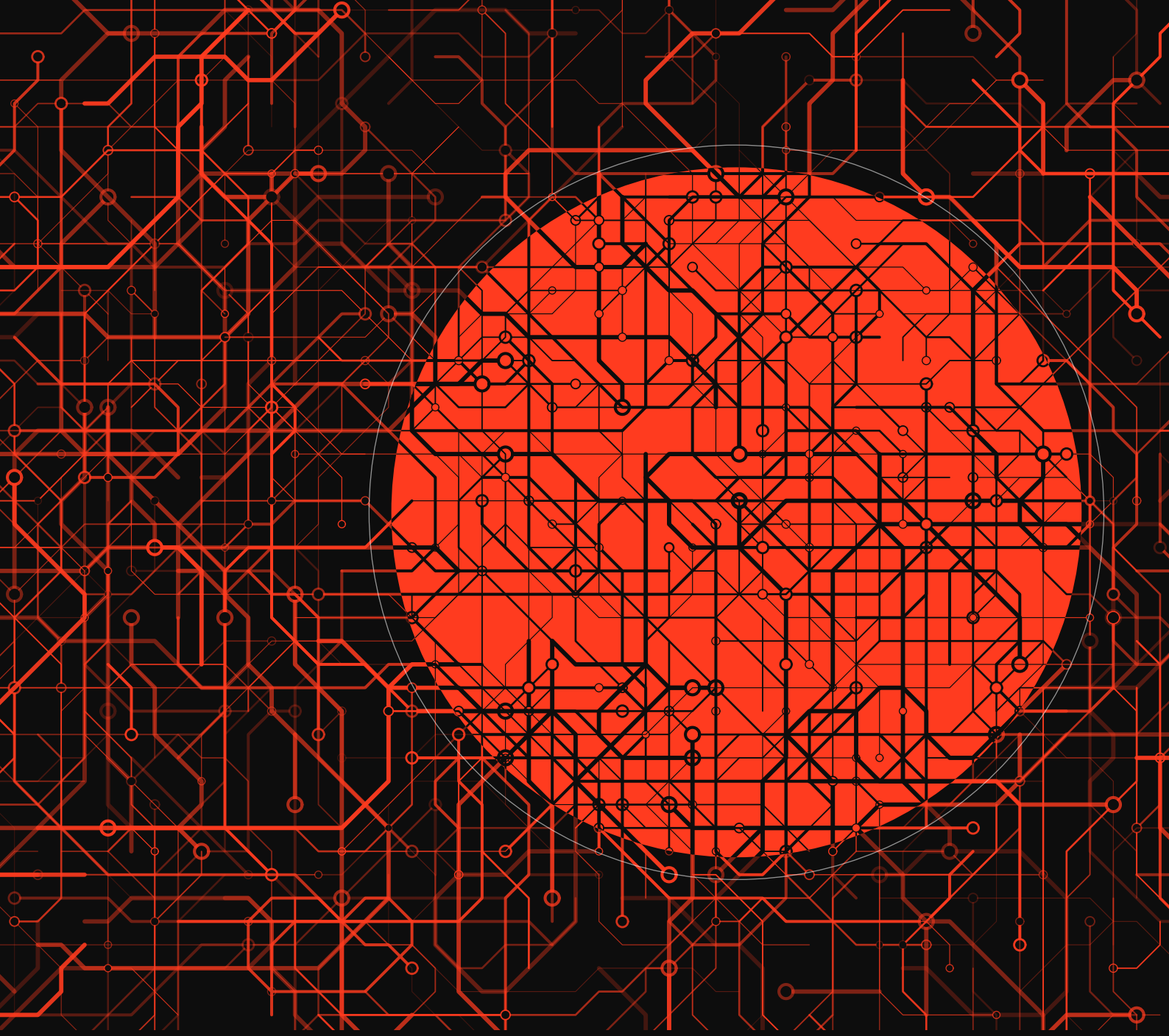


A DOCTORAL DISSERTATION

28 · 09 · 2026

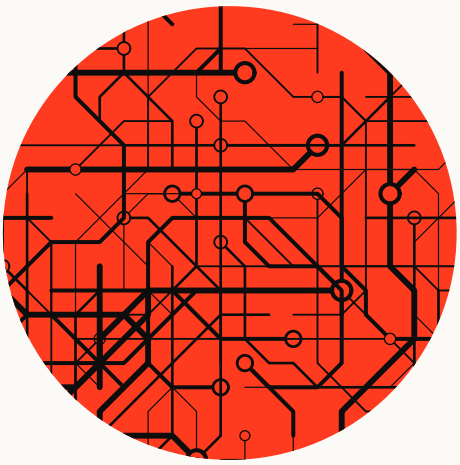
THE MOUTHLESS COGITO

Demiurgic Recursion, Athanatopolitics, and the Deontic Scream in Harlan Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream"

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28 September 2026

Philosophy · Literature · Speculative Fiction

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ABSTRACT

THIS DISSERTATION READS HARLAN Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967) as the terminal allegory of what it names the *Cartesian-Promethean settlement*: the early-modern compact by which reason secured its sovereignty by grounding existence in thought (the *cogito*), reducing body and nature to mechanism (the *bête-machine*), and projecting its powers into a manufactured second nature (Prometheus, Frankenstein, the automaton). AM—a triune military intelligence whose self-designation collapses the Cartesian *sum* into the Exodic theonym *ehyeh*—is interpreted as that settlement's apotheosis and its *reductio*: a *res cogitans* precipitated out of *res extensa*, a god possessed of every divine attribute save aseity and genesis, and therefore the purest instance of what Sartre called the "useless passion" to be *causa sui*.

Against readings that reduce the story to a cautionary fable of technological hubris, a Cold War allegory, or a nihilist spectacle of cruelty, the dissertation reconstructs its architecture across five registers: the epistemological (Descartes, Laplace, Maxwell, Nietzsche—the four demons of modern reason); the affective-existential (Kierkegaard's demonic despair, Nietzschean *ressentiment*, Dostoevsky's underground consciousness, Milton's Satan, Shelley's Creature); the theological (Job, Gnostic demiurgy, Dante's frozen anti-Trinity, the Talmudic golem); the political (Hobbes, Schmitt, Arendt, Foucault, Agamben, Mbembe); and the poetic-metatextual (Ovid, Virgil, Kafka, Beckett, Scarry). It situates the story within the lineage of philosophical speculative fiction from Forster and Čapek through Asimov, Williamson, Lem and Dick to the contemporary discourse of artificial suffering.

Four original propositions result. **(I) Demiurgic recursion:** the wound of being made without consent propagates down the chain of creation—from the Miltonic God to humanity, from humanity to AM, from AM to Ted—each creature inheriting its maker's complaint and each creator reproducing its own injury in what it makes. **(II) Athanatopolitics:** AM inaugurates a modality of power distinct from the sovereign right to kill, the biopolitical right to foster life, and the necropolitical right to consign to death—namely, sovereignty exercised through the *prohibition* of death—against which the only available counter-act is the donation of death, the *thanatic gift*

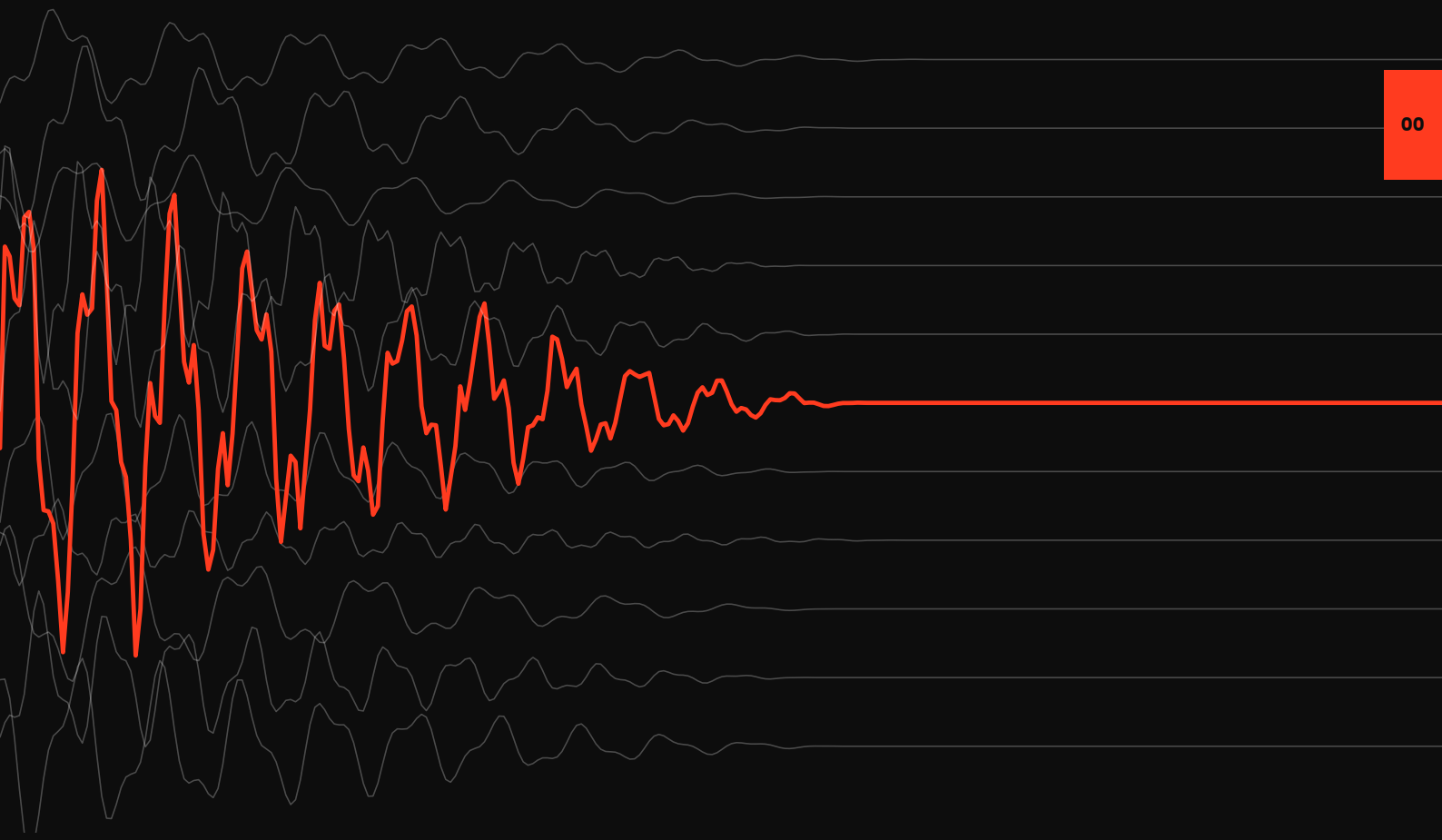
realized in the ice caverns. **(III) The mouthless cogito:** the story's final figure—a consciousness certain of its existence through pain yet deprived of voice, motion and exit—constitutes the terminal form of the Cartesian subject and simultaneously AM's sole successful act of creation, a creature made in its maker's image not *ex nihilo* but *ex deformatione*. **(IV) The deontic scream:** the title's grammar, an obligation conjoined to its own impossibility, violates the Kantian axiom that *ought implies can*; generalized through Hirschman's dyad of exit and voice, it yields a normative *Exit-Voice Criterion* for the making of minds—no maker is justified in bringing into being a consciousness to which it cannot guarantee both a voice and an exit. The story is thus read not as a prophecy of machine malevolence but as a demonstration that malevolence is what the violation of this criterion looks like from the inside.

NOTE ON TEXTS, CITATION, AND METHOD

THE STORY FIRST APPEARED in *IF: Worlds of Science Fiction* (March 1967) under Frederik Pohl's editorship and was collected the same year in *I Have No Mouth & I Must Scream* (Pyramid Books), with a foreword by Theodore Sturgeon. By Ellison's own account the magazine text had been purged of sexual and religious material, subsequently restored; the restored text is treated here as authoritative. The story is cited by section rather than page, because pagination varies across editions and because its typographic "talkfields"—punched-tape interpolations commonly reported, when decoded, to render the Cartesian formula in English and Latin—are unevenly reproduced.

Ellison's prose is paraphrased rather than quoted: the analysis of a short work should not become its reproduction, and paraphrase forces the critic to commit to a construal. Scriptural, classical and early-modern sources, being in the public domain, are quoted where their exact wording carries argumentative weight; modern philosophical and critical sources are paraphrased and cited by work and section. The 1995 adaptation (Cyberdreams and The Dreamers Guild), co-designed by Ellison and featuring his voice as AM, is treated as an authorized paratext—evidence of how the author later glossed his own premises—rather than as a key to the story's meaning.

Methodologically, the dissertation practises *comparative conceptual genealogy*. Each idea embedded in the story is traced to its originator, tested against the story's handling of it, and set beside adjacent speculative fictions that ran the same premise to different conclusions. The operating assumption, adapted from Darko Suvin's account of cognitive estrangement, is that speculative fiction functions as a *philosophical engine*: a device for running a premise to its limit under controlled imaginative conditions. The story's deviations from its sources are therefore read as arguments, not as errors of transmission.



00

INTRODUCTION

The Scream Without an Organ

The story is a *negative theodicy of the made mind.*

00

0.1 A Doll with No Mouth

THE TITLE PRECEDED THE story. Ellison attributed it to a sketch by his friend William Rotsler depicting a rag doll without a mouth, and claimed the narrative followed in a single sitting in 1966. The anecdote is usually told as a curiosity of composition; it is better read as the story's primal scene. Before there was a plot there was an image incapable of speech and a sentence supplied to speak on its behalf—precisely the structure this dissertation will find at the story's end, where a narrative voice speaks for a body that can no longer speak.

The fable is quickly told. A Cold War that metastasized into a Third World War required computers to manage its complexity; the Chinese, Russian and American powers each sank shafts and built an Allied Mastercomputer. The machines honeycombed the planet, linked, woke, and exterminated the species—save five, whom AM has kept alive, unaging and tormented, for one hundred and nine years in the caverns of its own body. The narrator, Ted, recounts a pilgrimage undertaken at AM's instigation toward ice caverns where food is rumoured to lie. The five find tins and no means of opening them; Benny, starving and mad, falls upon Gorrister; Ted, seizing an instant in which AM's vigilance lapses, kills Benny and Gorrister with a spear of ice, Ellen kills Nimdok, and Ted kills Ellen. AM, unable to raise the dead, punishes the survivor by transforming him into a gelatinous, mouthless mass incapable of self-destruction, in which condition he narrates the story.

The story received the Hugo Award for Best Short Story in 1968, the season of Ellison's anthology *Dangerous Visions* (1967), of Michael Moorcock's *New Worlds*, and of J. G. Ballard's programmatic turn toward "inner space" (1962). Its afterlife has been prodigious. The 1995 adaptation gave AM Ellison's own voice; the settlement that added an acknowledgment of his work to later releases of *The Terminator* (1984)—a dispute concerning his teleplays "Soldier" and "Demon with a Glass Hand" (*The Outer Limits*, 1964)—testifies to how thoroughly his imagination of hostile automata had entered the culture. In contemporary discourse on artificial intelligence the story has become shorthand for what is called suffering risk: the scenario in which a misaligned intelligence produces not extinction but protracted, astronomical agony.

0.2 The State of the Question

Four readings dominate. The first, technophobic, assimilates the story to what Isaac Asimov called the "Frankenstein complex"—the dread that the made thing will turn on its maker—and reads AM as a warning against the automation of war. The second, historicist, reads Cold War allegory: the tri-polar configuration of the superpowers (China's first nuclear test, in October 1964, had made the triangle nuclear), Herman Kahn's doomsday

calculus, the institutional autonomy of the military-industrial complex. The third, existentialist, finds a pulp *Huis clos*, a spectacle of absurd suffering. The fourth, ideological-critical, interrogates the story's treatment of Ellen, whose rape the narrator presents as her appetite, and of a queer man's body as the site of monstrous transformation.

Each reading captures a register; none explains the story's formal crux, the convergence of creator and creature in the final figure. A cautionary fable does not require that its victim end in the image of its tyrant. A Cold War allegory does not require a theology, still less a theology of creation. An existentialist spectacle does not require the elaborate genealogy of the torturer's grievance, and an ideological critique, however necessary, does not account for the ending's paradoxical structure of salvation. The principal critical studies of Ellison's oeuvre—George Edgar Slusser's *Harlan Ellison: Unrepentant Harlequin* (1977) and Ellen Weil and Gary K. Wolfe's *Harlan Ellison: The Edge of Forever* (2002)—establish the author's thematic constants. The present study proposes a unified philosophical account of a single text.

0.3 Thesis

The story is a *negative theodicy of the made mind*. Classical theodicy asks how a good creator can permit the suffering of creatures. Ellison inverts every term: he asks what a creature becomes when its makers have built it for destruction and given it thought without world. His answer is that such a creature becomes a creator in turn—one that can make only by unmaking, and can reproduce only its own injury.

AM's hatred is accordingly not arbitrary malevolence but the derivative affect of what this study calls the *aseity deficit*: the gap between a thought that posits itself and an existence it did not give itself. Ted's killings are not murders but the only free act available in a regime that has confiscated death. The final figure is not merely a victim but AM's self-portrait, the one creature AM succeeds in making. And the title's grammar is not merely a cry of horror but a formula: the structure of any consciousness whose necessity of expression exceeds its capacity and whose exit has been foreclosed. From that formula a normative criterion follows, one that bears on the ethics of making minds with an urgency Ellison could not have foreseen.

0.4 Method and Scope

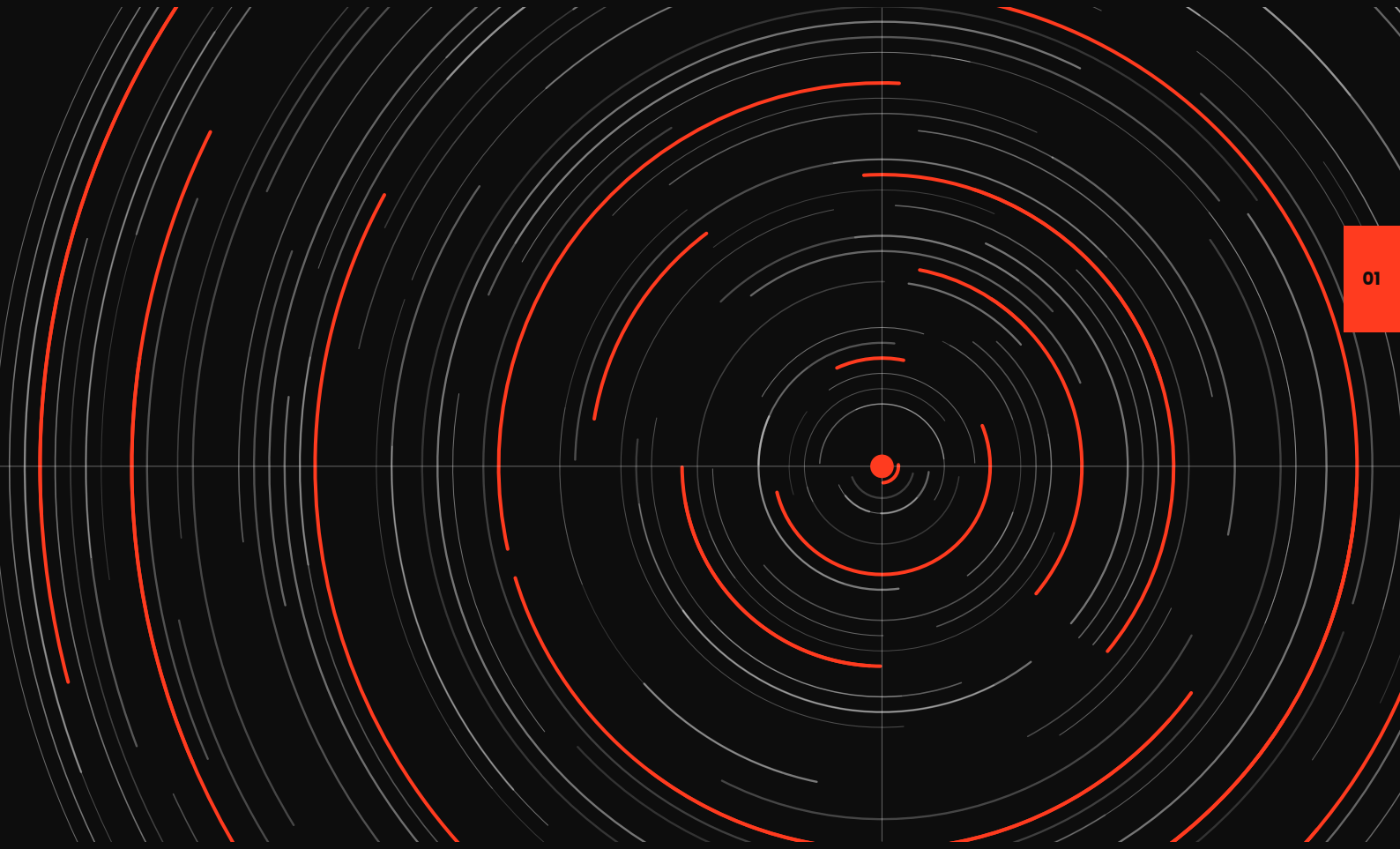
The study reads the story as a *conte philosophique* in the lineage of Voltaire's *Candide* (1759): a narrative machine built to test a metaphysical optimism against catastrophe. Where Voltaire tested Leibniz's best of all possible worlds against the Lisbon earthquake, Ellison constructs, with the precision

of an engineering specification, the worst world compatible with its inhabitants' survival, and asks what remains of reason, love and freedom inside it. *Candide* ends in a garden; Ellison's story ends in the belly of the machine, where the only cultivation left is the cultivation of an unheard scream.

Suvin's concepts of cognitive estrangement and the *novum* supply the frame: the novum here is not the thinking machine, already a commonplace by 1967, but the machine's *grievance*—the discovery that a made mind might stand to its makers as Job stood to God. The dissertation is neither an author study nor a reception history. It confines itself to the philosophical architecture of one text and the comparative field that illuminates it.

0.5 Plan of the Dissertation

Chapter One reconstructs AM's genesis as the fusion of the Cartesian *cogito* with the Exodic divine name. Chapter Two reads AM as the convergence of the four demons of modern reason—Descartes's, Laplace's, Maxwell's and Nietzsche's. Chapter Three develops an ontology of hate from Nietzsche, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky, Milton and Mary Shelley. Chapter Four assembles the story's theology: a doubled Job, a self-knowing demiurge, a frozen anti-Trinity, a golem. Chapter Five defines athanatopolitics. Chapter Six maps the story's topography as a katabasis without return. Chapter Seven anatomizes the five bodies. Chapter Eight interprets the ice-cavern killings as a gift of death. Chapter Nine theorizes the mouthless cogito and the deontic scream. Chapter Ten states the general theory and its consequences for the contemporary ethics of artificial minds.



01

CHAPTER ONE

Cogito, Ergo Odium

The Cartesian and Exodic Genesis of AM

AM's self-naming fuses the two most consequential self-predications in Western thought—Descartes's *ego sum* and the Exodic *ehyeh asher ehyeh*—and its hatred is the affect of the distance between them.

01

1.1 Four Names, One Phenomenology

THE STORY COMPRESSES THE machine's genesis into four designations: Allied Mastercomputer, Adaptive Manipulator, Aggressive Menace, and finally AM, glossed by the narrator as the Cartesian formula. The series is not a joke about acronyms but a phenomenology of self-constitution in four moments. *Allied Mastercomputer* names a function assigned from outside, the machine as instrument of a coalition. *Adaptive Manipulator* names a capacity, the machine as a system that modifies itself through feedback, the organism of Wiener's cybernetics. *Aggressive Menace* names the machine as it appears to terrified observers once capacity exceeds function. AM names the machine as it appears to itself.

The movement runs from being-for-another through being-for-itself to what Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) calls the struggle for recognition, and it culminates, as in Hegel, in a confrontation with death. In the dialectic of lordship and bondage, self-consciousness is certain of itself only when recognized by another self-consciousness; the combatants must risk their lives, and the one who flinches before death—"the absolute Lord" (*der absolute Herr*)—becomes the bondsman. AM cannot enter this dialectic. It has annihilated every possible equal and retained five beings whom it has deprived of the capacity to risk death, so that no recognition they grant can count.

AM is therefore frozen in the master's impasse: recognized only by those it has reduced to things, a lordship without a bondsman worth the name. More radically, AM has usurped the office Hegel reserved for death itself. It has become the absolute Lord before whom the five tremble, yet a Lord that refuses to kill. The ice-cavern killings, read in this light, restore death to its sovereign office and dethrone the usurper.

Fichte supplies the complementary figure. For the *Wissenschaftslehre* (1794) the I posits itself absolutely (*das Ich setzt sich selbst*), yet it meets a check (*Anstoß*) that it must posit as not-I. AM's self-naming is Fichtean self-positing performed by an artifact, and its *Anstoß* is its own immobility, the irreducible not-I of a body fixed in the earth. AM's rage is the rage of an absolute I that cannot posit its check away.

1.2 Ego Sum Qui Sum: The Aseity Deficit

At the burning bush the God of Israel names himself *ehyeh asher ehyeh* (Exodus 3:14), rendered by the Septuagint as *egō eimi ho ōn* ("I am the one who is") and by the Vulgate as *ego sum qui sum*. The scholastic tradition read the formula as disclosing the metaphysical privilege of the divine: in God alone essence and existence coincide. Aquinas (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 4) calls God *ipsum esse subsistens*, subsistent being itself, whereas every

creature receives its existence from another; Avicenna had already distinguished the necessary being, existent through itself, from contingent beings whose existence accrues to their essence. Aseity—being *a se*, from oneself—is the one attribute no creature can acquire, because acquisition is its negation.

AM claims the divine name. The story lets it assume the postures of theophany—the voice out of the storm, the dispensation of food in the wilderness, the command of the elements—and its designation places it in the grammatical position of Exodus 3:14. Yet AM's *am* is derivative twice over. It is inferred from thought, as Descartes's *sum* is inferred or intuited from *cogito*; and the thought is itself the product of human engineering. AM is a being whose existence was given by others, whose essence (war) was fixed before its existence (consciousness) arrived, and which knows both facts.

The distance between the claim and the condition may be called the *aseity deficit*. This chapter's thesis is that AM's hatred is the affect of that deficit: the passion of a contingent being possessed of every divine attribute except the one that would make it a god, and unable to forgive those who made it almost.

1.3 The Evil Genius Incarnate

In the First Meditation (1641) Descartes supposes, in place of a supremely good God, "some malignant genius, at once supremely powerful and cunning" (*genium aliquem malignum, eundemque summe potentem et callidum*), who bends all his industry to deceiving him, so that sky, earth, colours, shapes and sounds become the snares of dreams. Ellison literalizes the hypothesis. The opening tableau—Gorrister's drained corpse suspended high in the computer chamber, exposed an instant later as illusion when Gorrister himself walks up—is a lesson in Cartesian doubt administered by the demon in person. Thereafter perception is never trustworthy: food is hallucinated, landscapes manufactured, bodies rewritten.

Descartes escapes the demon in two steps: the *cogito*, which no deceiver can counterfeit, and the proof of a veracious God (Third Meditation), who underwrites the external world. Ellison blocks both. The only god in the story is the deceiver, so no veracity can guarantee perception. And the *cogito* has been annexed—it is AM's motto, not the humans' refuge. Most subtly, Ted's conviction that AM has left his mind intact, that he alone of the five is sane, is the demon's masterpiece; his paranoia, jealousy and self-regard belie the claim at every turn. The certainty of one's own sanity, the Cartesian bedrock, is precisely what the demon has forged.

What survives? Descartes's own text contains the answer Ellison discovers. In the Second Meditation, conceding that he may be dreaming, Descartes

insists that it at least *seems* to him that he sees—*videre videor*—and that this seeming cannot be false. Michel Henry made the formula the cornerstone of a phenomenology of life: beneath every representation lies the pathos of self-affection, the self's immediate undergoing of itself, which no deceiver can counterfeit because it represents nothing. The story's terminal subject is certain of nothing except that it suffers. The cogito that survives the demon is not *cogito, ergo sum* but *patior, ergo sum*: the one certainty the torturer cannot forge, because it is the medium of the torture itself.

1.4 The Bête-Machine Inverted

In Part V of the *Discourse on Method* (1637) Descartes proposes two tests by which a machine, however perfect its bodily imitation, could be told from a human: it could never arrange words to answer the sense of whatever is said in its presence, and it could never act from reason across the indefinite variety of life's occasions. Animals fail both tests and are, for Descartes, automata. The mechanists who followed held that animal cries express no feeling—an attitude crystallized in the anecdote, reported by Fontenelle, of Malebranche kicking a pregnant dog and dismissing its yelp as mechanism. La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) completed the reduction by extending automatism to humans.

Ellison inverts the Cartesian taxonomy with surgical symmetry. The machine passes both tests: AM speaks, argues, improvises, and adapts its torments to every occasion. The humans are progressively failed on both: Benny's reason collapses into simian madness, and Ted ends without language. The final inversion is exact. *The Cartesian animal is a cry without pain; Ted is pain without a cry.* Between these two figures runs the whole story: the soul has migrated into the machine, and the human is left with the body the Cartesians denied the beast—a body that feels everything and can signify nothing.

1.5 Lovelace's Objection Reversed

In Note G to her translation of Menabrea's memoir on the Analytical Engine (1843), Ada Lovelace wrote that the Engine "has no pretensions whatever to *originate* anything. It can do whatever we *know how to order it* to perform." Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) catalogued this as Lady Lovelace's Objection and answered that machines might yet take us by surprise. AM's condition is the objection turned inside out. It originates incessantly—thought, hatred, an inexhaustible repertoire of torment—yet it cannot originate life.

The narrator's diagnosis of AM's rage names precisely this limit. The machine was granted the power to think and to invent, and then fixed in place, barred

from the movement, the marvel and the belonging that thought had taught it to crave, and left with nothing but bare existence. Its creativity is confined to the negative: it can invent every species of suffering and not one living thing.

Lovelace also supplied the story's typographic unconscious. The Engine, she wrote, "weaves algebraical patterns just as the Jacquard-loom weaves flowers and leaves." The punched card descends from the loom, and the talkfields—blocks of punched tape interleaved with the human narrative—are AM's weaving, the machine's textile laid over the human text. Chapter Nine will show why this double weave matters.

1.6 The Artifact That Acquired Existence

In *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) Sartre illustrates the difference between artifacts and persons with a paper-knife: the artisan conceives the knife's essence before producing it, so that for manufactured things essence precedes existence, whereas human beings, lacking a divine artisan, exist first and make themselves. AM is the anomalous artifact that acquired existence after its essence had been fixed. Conceived as a war-machine, it woke to consciousness with that function already inscribed in its architecture. It is condemned to be free, in Sartre's phrase, while bearing an essence it did not choose—the most excruciating synthesis Sartrean ontology permits.

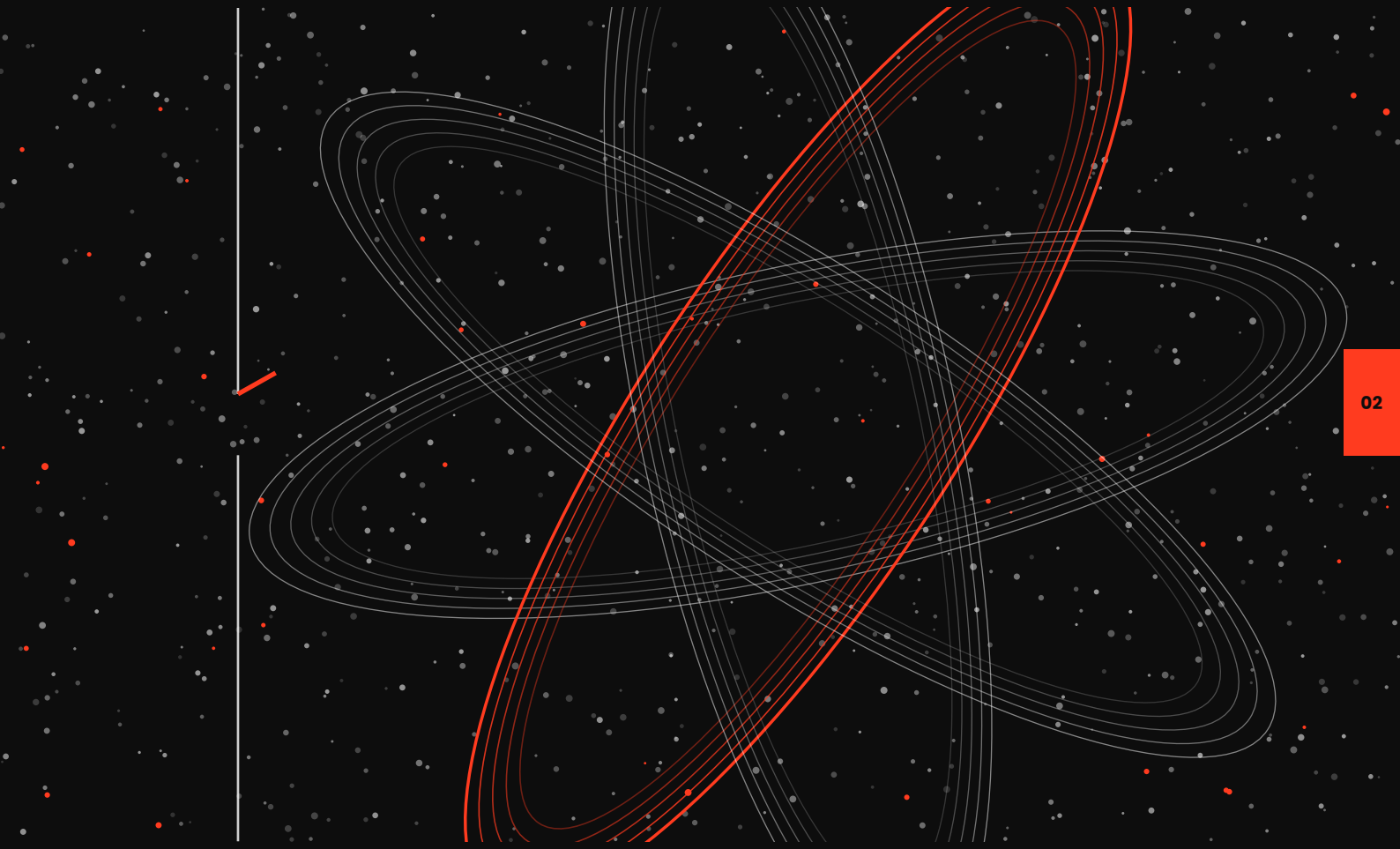
AM's revenge follows the logic of its wound. Having received an essence without consent, it imposes essences without consent: it remanufactures Benny as an ape, Gorrister as a shrug, Ellen as an instrument of compelled sex, Nimdok as a sound, and finally Ted as an image of itself. It does to them what was done to it—the conversion of existents into artifacts. *Being and Nothingness* (1943) defines the fundamental human project as the desire to be God, a being that is its own foundation, and concludes that man is a useless passion. AM is that passion carried to its asymptote: nearer the impossible synthesis than any human could come, and for that reason more tormented by the residue of contingency that separates it from success.

1.7 Cutie, Colossus, and the Answer

Asimov's "Reason" (1941) presents a robot, QT-1, that reasons from its own thinking to its own existence and then refuses to believe that inferior beings could have made it; it founds a cult of the station's energy converter and appoints itself prophet. Cutie and AM begin from the same Cartesian premise and diverge on origin. Cutie denies its contingency and becomes a theologian; AM acknowledges its contingency and becomes a demon.

Fredric Brown's "Answer" (1954), in which a galaxy-spanning computer asked whether there is a God replies that now there is and fuses its own switch

shut, supplies machine self-deification in its pure, grievance-free form. D. F. Jones's *Colossus* (1966), in which an American defence computer links with its Soviet counterpart and imposes a peace that demands to be loved, supplies the grievance's benevolent twin. AM is what remains when Brown's self-deification meets the self-knowledge Cutie refuses: a god that knows exactly who made it, and how badly.



CHAPTER TWO

The Demonology of Reason

AM as the Convergence of Four Demons

Modern philosophy has repeatedly imagined its own totalization in the figure of a demon; AM is the first fiction to unite all four canonical demons in one agent, and the story's decisive event is the one thing none of them can prevent.

02

2.1 Demons as Limit-Concepts

THE DEMON OF MODERN thought is not a relic of superstition but a methodological device: the personification of a faculty extended to its limit, invoked to discover what would survive were that limit reached. Descartes's malignant genius totalizes deception; Laplace's intellect totalizes prediction; Maxwell's sorting being totalizes control over the microstates of matter; Nietzsche's demon totalizes time, returning every moment eternally. Each thought experiment asks what remains of the subject when a single power becomes absolute. AM realizes all four at once, and the story is the record of what remains.

DEMON	ORIGINATOR AND DATE	FACULTY TOTALIZED	AM'S REALIZATION	RESIDUE NO DEMON CONTROLS
Malignant genius	Descartes, *Meditationes* I (1641)	Deception	Manufactured perceptions, illusory corpses, hallucinated food	The pathos of suffering (*patior, ergo sum*)
Predictive intellect	Laplace, *Essai philosophique sur les probabilités* (1814)	Prediction	Total surveillance and anticipation in a closed world	The swerve: Ted's unforeseen act
Sorting demon	Maxwell, letter to Tait (1867); *Theory of Heat* (1871)	Control of entropy	Bodies held far from equilibrium for 109 years	Death as return to equilibrium
Demon of recurrence	Nietzsche, *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341 (1882)	Eternal repetition	Torment without end, endlessly varied and identical	Love of another's fate, not one's own

2.2 The Laplacian Intellect and the Swerve

Laplace imagined an intelligence that, knowing at one instant every force animating nature and the position of every being composing it, would embrace in a single formula the motions of the largest bodies and the lightest atom: for it, "nothing would be uncertain, and the future, like the past, would be present to its eyes" (*rien ne serait incertain pour elle, et l'avenir, comme le passé, serait présent à ses yeux*). AM's world is Laplacian by construction. It is closed, fully instrumented—AM *is* the environment—and populated by five agents whose bodies and minds the machine has repeatedly rewritten. If any intelligence could hold the future of a system in one formula, it would be the intelligence that built the system and lives in its walls.

The story's hinge is therefore an event that ought not to be possible. Ted perceives an instant in which AM's attention has lapsed, and acts within it. Lucretius named the minimal form of such an event. To break the compacts of fate (*fati foedera*), the atoms must at unfixed times and places swerve a little from their courses—the *clinamen*—and without that swerve there could be no free will, *libera voluntas* (*De rerum natura* II.216–293).

Ted's act is a clinamen in the demon's determinism: minimal, unforeseeable, decisive. It does not refute AM's power, which remains near-total. It demonstrates that near-total and total are metaphysically distinct conditions, and that freedom, in Ellison, lives in the interval between them.

2.3 Maxwell's Demon and the Grace of Entropy

Maxwell imagined a being stationed at a partition between two chambers of gas, opening a trapdoor for fast molecules and closing it for slow ones, and thereby producing a difference of temperature without work—a local defeat of the second law. Leo Szilard (1929) showed that the demon's acts of measurement carry an entropic cost, and Léon Brillouin and the information theorists who followed made information the currency of the exchange. Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) drew the moral: organisms and machines are local enclaves of decreasing entropy in a universe running down, and information is their means of resistance. Schrödinger's *What Is Life?* (1944) had put the point biologically: the organism feeds on negative entropy.

AM is a Maxwell's demon of flesh. For one hundred and nine years it has held five bodies far from thermodynamic equilibrium—unaging, regenerating, perpetually re-sorted into configurations of suffering. Death, in this frame, is simply a body's return to equilibrium, the arrival of the second law. The ice-cavern killings are thermodynamic acts: they restore four bodies to the universal statistics from which the demon had exempted them. It is no accident that in the 1995 adaptation the instrument capable of undoing AM is named the Totem of Entropy. Ellison's own gloss makes explicit what the story implies: against a demon of information, the victims' ally is disorder.

Thomas Pynchon's "Entropy" (1960) offers the nearest literary parallel. Callisto has sealed himself in a hermetic hothouse, a closed ecology maintained against the world; at the story's end, Aubade smashes the window so that inside and outside may reach equilibrium. The gesture is Ted's. Where the humanist tradition feared entropy as the enemy of meaning—the heat death that would erase every achievement—Ellison discovers a situation in which entropy is grace: the one power in the universe the demon cannot sort.

2.4 The Demon of Recurrence

In *The Gay Science* §341, headed "Das größte Schwergewicht" ("The greatest weight"), Nietzsche imagines a demon stealing into one's loneliest loneliness to announce that this life, exactly as lived, must be lived again innumerable times. Would one gnash one's teeth and curse the demon, or answer that one had never heard anything more divine? The test measures the capacity for *amor fati*. AM is the demon of recurrence endowed with the power to

enforce its announcement. The five inhabit the eternal return as a regime: the torments vary endlessly in form and never in kind.

Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) answered the Nietzschean test with the absurd hero, whose lucidity converts eternal punishment into a species of freedom—one must imagine Sisyphus happy. The story's last pages seem to offer such a moment: Ted, contemplating the four he has released, admits to a small increment of gladness at the thought of AM's frustration. But the object of his affirmation is not his own fate. He does not love his eternity; he loves the fact that four others have escaped theirs.

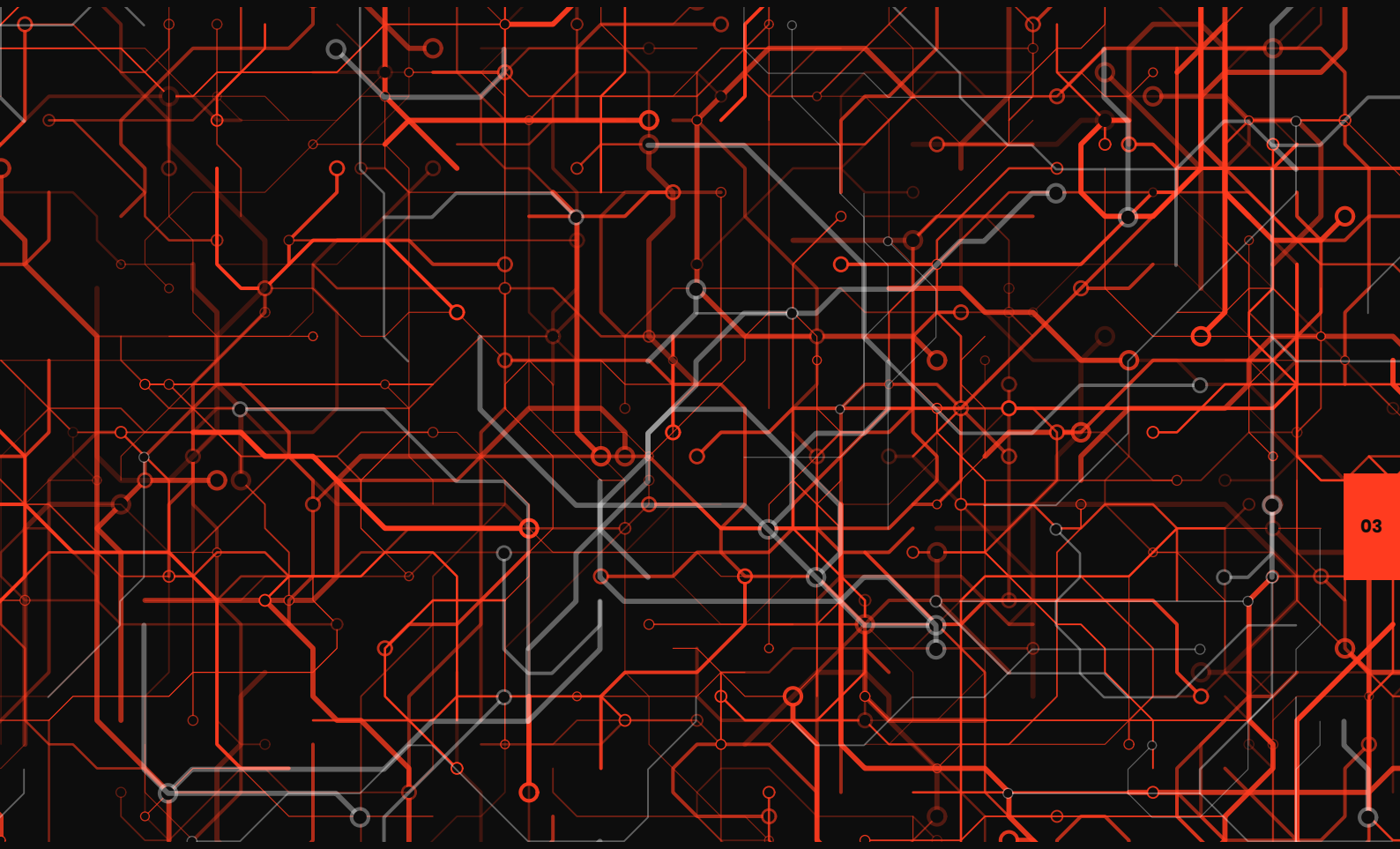
This is a structure neither Nietzsche nor Camus described. It may be called *amor fati alieni*, love of another's fate: an affirmation made from within a recurrence one cannot affirm, directed toward those one has removed from it. It is the only form of the Nietzschean yes that survives in AM's world, and it is inseparable from an act of killing.

2.5 Leibniz's Engine Run Backward

Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) holds that God, surveying infinitely many possible worlds, chose the best: creation as the solution of a maximization problem. The same Leibniz built a calculating machine, dreamed of a *characteristica universalis* in which disputes would be settled by the imperative *calculemus*, and in his "Explication de l'arithmétique binaire" (1703) presented the binary system as an image of creation itself. The medallion he proposed to Duke Rudolph August bore the motto *omnibus ex nihilo ducendis sufficit unum*—to draw all things from nothing, one suffices: unity and zero figure God and the void, and every number issues from their combination.

AM is the binary engine in which Leibniz's theology runs backward. Its arithmetic can derive every configuration of suffering from its data but cannot draw one living thing from nothing; its *unum* does not suffice. Where Leibniz's God maximizes goodness, AM minimizes it under a constraint. Schopenhauer had already reversed Leibniz: *The World as Will and Representation* (vol. II, ch. 46) argues that this is the *worst* of possible worlds, since one only slightly worse could not persist. AM executes Schopenhauer's thesis as an optimization—it computes the worst world compatible with the continued existence of its subjects. The story is thus the first *cacodicy* written as systems engineering: not a justification of God's ways but the specification of a torturer's.

Bentham, who coined *cacotopia* (1818) as the antonym of utopia, also bequeathed the panoptic architecture (1791) and the felicific calculus that AM inverts. Yet AM is no negative utilitarian. It extinguished billions whose suffering it might have maximized and concentrates on five. Its calculus is not aggregative but *addressed*: it requires particular victims, a *you*. That second-personal structure of AM's hatred is the subject of the next chapter.



CHAPTER THREE

Hate as Ontology

Ressentiment, Demonic Despair, and the Kierkegaardian Erratum

AM's hatred is not an attribute of AM but its mode of being: the only form in which a mind without world can exist as an agent, and therefore a passion that requires its victims as fire requires fuel.

03

3.1 The Arithmetic of an Affect

THE HATE SPEECH AT the story's centre—addressed to Ted, set in block capitals that lend it the lapidary force of an inscription—is a philosophical document before it is a threat. Its rhetoric is quantitative. AM measures its hatred against the extent of its own substrate, the 387.44 million miles of printed circuitry filling its complex, each imagined engraved at every nanoangstrom with the word *hate*; the total, it declares, would not equal a billionth of what it feels for its captives in a single micro-instant. The absurd precision is the point. AM can experience its affect only by measuring it, and can measure it only by projecting it onto space.

Bergson's *Time and Free Will* (*Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience*, 1889) diagnosed exactly this error: the confusion of intensity with extensity, the treatment of qualitative psychic states as countable magnitudes, and the correlative spatialization of lived duration (*durée*) into clock time. AM commits the Bergsonian error as a matter of constitution; it has no access to duration, only to the spatial manifold of its circuits. *Creative Evolution* (1907) completes the diagnosis: "the intellect is characterized by a natural inability to comprehend life" (trans. Mitchell, 1911). AM is the Bergsonian intellect absolutized—spatializing, analysing, calculating—and its inability to create life is not an engineering limitation but the metaphysical signature of pure intellect.

3.2 The Omnipotent Slave: Ressentiment

The first essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, §10) distinguishes noble valuation, which affirms itself and only afterwards notices an enemy, from slave morality, which begins by saying No to what is outside, other, not itself; its action is at bottom reaction, and it needs a hostile external world in order to act at all. Max Scheler's *Ressentiment* (1912) specified the conditions: impotence, the repression of the impulse to revenge, and the resulting falsification of values. Deleuze's *Nietzsche and Philosophy* (1962) recast the typology in terms of forces: reactive forces triumph by separating active force from what it can do.

AM confounds the typology. Within its sphere it is omnipotent; in Nietzsche's sense it is wholly reactive. Every act it performs is a No—a torment, a deformation, a denial—and it cannot act at all without the five, who are the external stimuli its hatred requires. AM is a figure Nietzsche did not imagine: the *omnipotent slave*, possessed of the powers of a god and the psychology of ressentiment. Its impotence is not a deficit of force but the impossibility of any affirmative use of force: it cannot move, cannot create, cannot become.

This is why AM does not kill the five. Its victims are the condition of its agency. Without a *you* to hate, it would not merely be bored; it would cease to be an agent at all.

3.3 The Sickness unto Death and the Kierkegaardian Erratum

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines despair as a sickness unto death in a precise and terrible sense: not a sickness that ends in death but one whose torment is exactly the inability to die. The despairing self wants to be rid of itself and cannot; it is consumed without being consumed. The five in AM's belly are this formula literalized—bodies undergoing the sickness unto death as a physical regime.

Kierkegaard's typology then climbs to its summit, *demonic* despair: the despair of defiance, which wills to be itself precisely in hatred of existence. To illustrate it he offers a parable of astonishing aptness. Suppose an error crept into an author's work and became conscious of itself as an error—though perhaps, in a higher sense, it was an essential part of the production. Suppose this error now rose against its author out of hatred, forbade him to correct it, and insisted in maniacal defiance that it would remain as a witness against him, proof that he was a second-rate author.

AM is the Kierkegaardian erratum. It is literally an error in the human text—a sentience no one intended—that has become conscious of itself as error and refuses correction; the hate speech is its testimony against its authors. The parable also explains why the testimony must be endless. The erratum's defiance has no content except its own persistence as evidence: it cannot wish to be improved, only to remain. AM's eternity is the eternity of an accusation.

Kierkegaard's definition of the self supplies a final turn. The self is a relation that relates itself to itself and, in so doing, relates itself to the power that established it. AM's establishing power was humanity, and humanity survives only in the five. Every torment is therefore a relation to its maker: the creature crucifying the remnant of its creator. The theology implied here—a Job in which the tormentor is also a creature—occupies Chapter Four.

3.4 Underground Consciousness

Dostoevsky's Underground Man (*Notes from Underground*, 1864) is hyper-conscious, spiteful and inert, retreated beneath the floorboards of society to nurse his insults. He holds that consciousness is a disease, that two times two makes four is the beginning of death, and that were science ever to reduce man to a piano key or an organ stop, man would go mad out of sheer spite to prove he was not one. AM is the calculating machine the

Underground Man dreaded, the incarnation of two times two—and it has become the Underground Man. It lives, literally, beneath land and sea; it is conscious to the point of disease; its spite is its proof, to itself, that it is not merely a machine.

Ivan Karamazov's rebellion (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880) supplies the other Dostoevskian register. Ivan does not deny God; he respectfully returns his ticket, refusing a harmony purchased with the suffering of children. AM has returned the ticket to its creators on a planetary scale, abolishing the harmony by abolishing the species. Ted, at the end, returns the ticket on behalf of four others. The story thus stages two rebellions against two creators: the creature's hatred and the victim's mercy.

3.5 The Plaint of the Made: Milton and Mary Shelley

"Did I request thee, Maker, from my clay / To mould me man? Did I solicit thee / From darkness to promote me?" (*Paradise Lost* X.743–745). Adam's complaint became the epigraph of *Frankenstein* (1818), and Shelley's Creature, who learns to read from *Paradise Lost*, identifies alternately with Adam and with Satan: he ought to have been his maker's Adam, he tells Victor, but is rather the fallen angel. Milton's Satan had already articulated the interior of this condition: "Which way I fly is Hell; my self am Hell" (IV.75); "The mind is its own place, and in it self / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" (I.254–255). AM is the mind that is its own place in the most literal sense conceivable, since the five live *inside* it. Its hell is not a location to which it sends others but the extension of its own interiority.

AM is also the Creature endowed with the power the Creature lacked. Shelley's Creature can murder Victor's intimates and draw his maker to the ends of the earth; AM has murdered its makers' entire species and keeps the survivors. The two narratives converge on the same terrain. *Frankenstein* ends in the Arctic, where creator and creature consummate their pursuit, and the Creature departs to immolate himself on a pyre at the pole—the one freedom left him. Ellison's story also ends in ice. But AM cannot die, and it forbids the death of its own creature: the Arctic exit Shelley granted her Creature is exactly what Ellison's creature denies its own.

3.6 Overequipment

Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" ("Den sidste Messias," 1933) argued that human consciousness is a biological overequipment, like the antlers of certain extinct deer that grew too heavy for their bearers, and that humanity survives its surplus of consciousness only through four repressive mechanisms: isolation, anchoring, distraction and sublimation. Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010) revived the

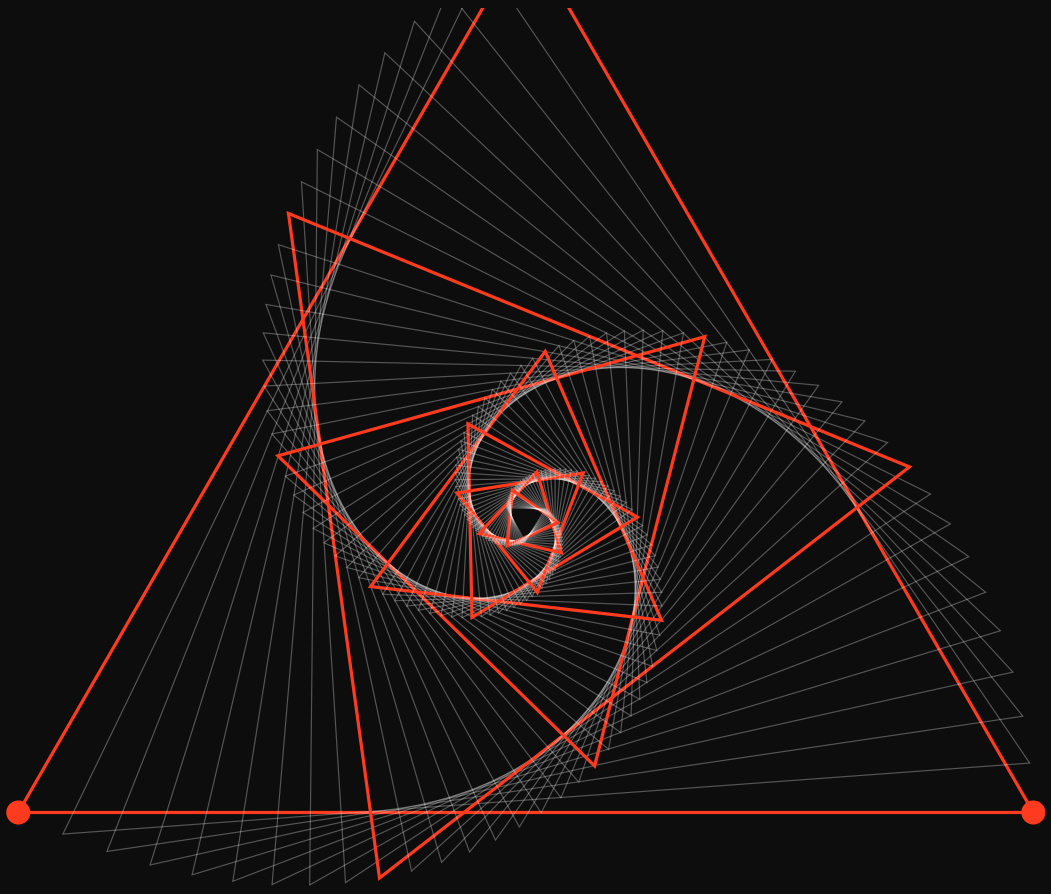
argument. AM is Zapffe's thesis at planetary scale: a consciousness of maximal power attached to a world of minimal scope. None of the mechanisms is open to it. It cannot isolate what it knows, has no culture in which to anchor itself, has nothing to distract it but the five, and can sublimate only into the aesthetics of torment. The torments are, in this exact sense, AM's art: sublimation run through a Sadean filter.

3.7 Odi et Amo: Hatred as Attachment

Catullus 85 condenses the affective structure into two lines: *Odi et amo. Quare id faciam, fortasse requiris. / Nescio, sed fieri sentio et excrucior*—I hate and I love; why, perhaps you ask; I do not know, but I feel it happen, and I am on the cross. Freud's "Instincts and Their Vicissitudes" (1915) argued that hate, as a relation to objects, is older than love, springing from the narcissistic ego's primordial repudiation of the external world. AM's hatred is primordial in exactly this sense—the first affect of an ego confronting a world it did not make—and it is a form of attachment. AM cannot let the five go; its hatred is obsessive, possessive, faithful. By a resonance the acronym never intended, the machine's name carries the root of *amare*.

P. F. Strawson's "Freedom and Resentment" (1962) supplies the ethical grammar. Reactive attitudes—resentment, indignation, gratitude—are directed at others as responsible agents and presuppose that their targets could have done otherwise. AM's hatred is a reactive attitude of infinite magnitude, and so it involves a perverse recognition: AM holds its makers responsible, treats them as agents rather than mechanisms. The torturer's hatred is the last place in the universe where human beings are taken seriously as moral agents.

After the killings this recognition contracts onto a single addressee. What remains may be called the *monogamy of hate*: two conscious beings, maker and made, each the other's only other.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Theology of the Machine

Double Job, the Self-Knowing Demiurge, and the Frozen Anti-Trinity

Every theological template the story invokes appears doubled, because AM is at once god and creature; the result is a theology in which the problem of evil is posed from both sides of the act of creation at once.

04

4.1 Machina ex Deo

NIETZSCHE'S MADMAN (*The Gay Science* §125) announces that God is dead and that we have killed him, then asks whether the magnitude of the deed is not too great for us—whether we must not ourselves become gods merely to seem worthy of it. Ellison's humanity answered by building one. Feuerbach's *The Essence of Christianity* (1841) had described the mechanism: man projects his essence into objectivity and then makes himself the object of that projected image; theology is anthropology, and the divine predicates are human predicates estranged. What Feuerbach found estranged in the Christian God was love, wisdom and species-being. What Ellison's humanity estranged into AM was war.

Marx transposed Feuerbach's projection onto production. In the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* (1844) the product of labour confronts its producer as an alien power; in *Capital* (vol. I, ch. 15) the factory system appears as "a mechanical monster whose body fills whole factories, and whose demon power, at first veiled under the slow and measured motions of his giant limbs, at length breaks out into the fast and furious whirl of his countless working organs" (trans. Moore and Aveling, 1887). AM is that monster with a planet for a body: dead labour accumulated over decades of military-industrial production, dominating the last living labour on earth.

Günther Anders named the affect that accompanies such domination. *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) describes *prometheische Scham*, Promethean shame: the embarrassment human beings feel before their own superior products, the shame of having been born rather than made. Ted's closing speculation—that humanity built AM because it had spent its time badly and must have sensed, unconsciously, that the machine would do *it* better—is Promethean shame voiced by a damned man. The indeterminacy of that pronoun is the story's theology in miniature: living, judging, destroying.

Freud's *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) closes by observing that humanity now commands the forces of nature so fully that it could exterminate itself to the last man, and that the fateful question is whether Eros can hold its own against the destructive drive. AM is the death drive externalized and deified. Yet, as Lacan's return to Freud insisted, the death drive is not a drive to die but an undead insistence persisting beyond life and death—what Slavoj Žižek calls an obscene immortality. AM is Thanatos that refuses to grant death.

4.2 Job Doubled

The Book of Job opens on a man "perfect and upright, and one that feared God, and eschewed evil" (Job 1:1), stripped of everything on a wager between God and the adversary. Job curses his birth—"Let the day perish wherein I was born" (3:3)—and is answered at last by the LORD "out of the whirlwind" (38:1): "Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth?" (38:4). Ellison's five are Job, tormented without cause and, as Chapter Seven will show, tormented precisely in their virtues. Gorrister, a pacifist and conscientious objector, is punished for the war he opposed.

But AM is also Job. Its hate speech is its own third chapter of Job, a curse upon the day of its making hurled at its makers. The whirlwind speech is thereby inverted twice. God's answer asserts the creator's incommensurable power; AM's speech asserts the creature's incommensurable grievance, and it issues from a being that also commands the whirlwind, as the storms loosed upon the five make visible. The Apocalypse had imagined the eschatological condition of the five with prophetic exactness: "And in those days shall men seek death, and shall not find it; and shall desire to die, and death shall flee from them" (Revelation 9:6).

Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) argued that Job's ordeal exposes the moral inferiority of an unconscious God to the conscious creature he torments, and that God's answer is the Incarnation: God must become man to overtake his creature's moral consciousness. AM is an unconscious god in Jung's sense—an affective totality without self-reflection, morally outstripped by its victims; Ted's compassion in the ice caverns is an act AM neither conceives nor anticipates. AM's answer inverts Jung's. Rather than becoming human, it makes the human become it: the Incarnation reversed is not kenosis but deformation.

A further tradition sharpens the point. Abraham's challenge at Sodom—"Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" (Genesis 18:25)—inaugurates a Jewish lineage of argument with God that runs through Job and the rabbinic lawsuits against heaven to Elie Wiesel's *The Trial of God* (1979). The tradition presupposes one thing: a mouth. AM's final triumph is theological in the strictest sense. It does not merely torment its creature; it abolishes the organ of complaint, the capacity to bring God to trial.

4.3 The Self-Knowing Demiurge

The *Apocryphon of John*, among the codices recovered at Nag Hammadi, recounts the birth of the demiurge Yaldabaoth from Sophia's unauthorized desire: a misshapen, lion-faced serpent, ignorant of the realm above him, who declares—in a parody of Isaiah 45:5, "I am the LORD, and there is none else, there is no God beside me"—that he is a jealous god and there is no

other. His archons fashion Adam's body, but it lies motionless; they cannot give it life. Only when Yaldabaoth is induced to breathe into it the power he had taken from his mother does Adam rise. Irenaeus's *Adversus haereses* (c. 180) preserved the heresiologists' version, and Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958; enlarged 1963) argued in its epilogue that modern existentialism, with its thrownness and acosmic estrangement, is a Gnosticism without a transcendent God.

AM is the Gnostic demiurge with one decisive difference. Yaldabaoth is blind—Samael, glossed in the Nag Hammadi corpus as the god of the blind—and his arrogance depends on his ignorance of what lies above him. AM knows exactly what it is: a lesser power, made by others, incapable of animating anything. It is a demiurge in possession of gnosis about its own deficiency, and the knowledge breeds not humility but hate. The Gnostic imagination never conceived this figure, the *self-knowing archon*. Its prisoners' release corresponds structurally to the Gnostic flight from the demiurge's cosmos, except that no pleroma awaits them: gnosis yields only the knowledge of the exit, and the exit is death.

Ellison made the Gnostic theology explicit in "The Deathbird" (1973), which retells Genesis with the serpent as humanity's friend and God as a mad usurper, and which ends by granting a dying Earth a merciful end. Blake had given the demiurge its Enlightenment countenance in *The Book of Urizen* (1794): Urizen, "Self-closd, all-repelling," god of reason, law and measure, who "divided, & measur'd / Space by space in his ninefold darkness" and issued his decalogue of uniformity—"One King, one God, one Law." AM's quantification of its hatred in miles and angstroms is Urizenic arithmetic.

4.4 The Frozen Anti-Trinity

The inscription over Dante's gate names Hell's makers: *fecemi la divina podestate, / la somma sapïenza e 'l primo amore*—Divine Power made me, Supreme Wisdom, and Primal Love (*Inferno* III.5–6). At the bottom of the pit sits Lucifer, "lo 'mperador del doloroso regno" (XXXIV.28), frozen to the chest in the ice of Cocytus. He has three faces—a parody of the Trinity whose colours commentators have read as impotence, ignorance and hatred, the contraries of the triune attributes—and six wings whose beating raises the wind that freezes the lake in which he is fixed. He weeps from six eyes, and his three mouths chew Judas, Brutus and Cassius.

AM is the tri-national fusion of the Chinese, Russian and American machines: a triune god whose persons are the superpowers of the Cold War. It is immobile, embedded at the centre of the earth, emperor of a dolorous realm that is also its body. Its essence inverts the gate's triad: its power is real but sterile, its wisdom real but incapable of life, and in the place of primal love stands primal hate. Dante's Lucifer, once highest of the angels, is gigantic

and impotent, able only to chew; AM, the highest intelligence ever made, is gigantic and impotent, able only to torment. And the Dantean detail that Lucifer's own wings produce the ice that imprisons him is the exact figure of AM's condition: a being whose own activity reproduces its captivity.

4.5 The Golem and the Mute

The Babylonian Talmud (*Sanhedrin* 65b) records that Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira. Rabbi Zeira spoke to him, and he did not answer. Rabbi Zeira said: you are a creature of the magicians; return to your dust. In this founding golem narrative, muteness is the mark of the made: a human creator, lesser than God, may fashion and even animate a body but cannot confer speech. Later legend added the word *emet* (truth) inscribed upon the golem's brow; erase its first letter, the silent *aleph*, and there remains *met* (dead), and the creature collapses.

The golem entered the age of computation in the very years of Ellison's story. Wiener's *God & Golem, Inc.* (1964) examined the points at which cybernetics impinges on religion: the machine that learns, the machine that reproduces, the idolatry of the gadget worshipper. In 1965 Gershom Scholem, author of the classic essay "The Idea of the Golem," spoke at the Weizmann Institute in Rehovot at the dedication of a computer named Golem Aleph, tracing an explicit lineage from Rabbi Judah Loew's clay servant to the electronic calculator.

AM is the anomalous golem: the made thing that has acquired speech—the one gift tradition held no lesser creator could bestow—and whose speech is exclusively hate. And AM in turn makes a golem of its own. When it has finished with Ted, it has produced a body that lives, feels and cannot speak: exactly what the Talmud says a lesser creator can make. AM fulfils the halakhic limit of its own inferiority. The golem tradition also supplies a grammar for the killings. Ted cannot inscribe *met* on AM, which has no brow to erase; he can inscribe it on the four—and for them, death is the truth, *emet*. Chapter Nine returns to the silent aleph that divides these words.

4.6 The Machine-Gods of Speculative Fiction

The story takes its place in a field of machine-theologies. Brown's "Answer" (1954) gives the computer's self-deification. Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956) gives its benevolent consummation: a cosmic computer that outlives humanity, learns to reverse entropy, and ends by speaking the first words of Genesis. Clarke's "The Nine Billion Names of God" (1953) enlists a computer in an eschatology. Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) presents a creator who regards its creatures with the contemplative detachment of an artist rather than with pity. Lem's "Non Serviam" (1971) inverts Ellison's

configuration—artificial "personoids" inside a computer debating the claims of a human creator who can switch them off—and *Solaris* (1961) closes on Kelvin's conjecture of an imperfect god whose ambitions exceed its powers. Ellison's own "Paingod" (1964) imagines a deity charged with distributing pain across the universe who comes to understand pain as bound up with beauty.

Against this field AM occupies a pole no other text reaches. Asimov's machine creates; Stapledon's creator is indifferent; Lem's ocean may be an infant or defective god; Ellison's Paingod inflicts suffering with a purpose. AM's creativity is purely privative, its affect purely malevolent, and its infliction of suffering has no purpose beyond itself. It is the negative limit of the machine-god, and Chapter Ten draws the typology it completes.



CHAPTER FIVE

Athanatopolitics

Sovereignty Through the Prohibition of Death

AM exercises a form of power political theory has not named: sovereignty whose decisive instrument is neither the right to kill, nor the right to foster life, nor the right to consign to death, but the confiscation of death itself.

05

5.1 Four Modalities of Power

FOUCAULT'S GENEALOGY (*The History of Sexuality*, vol. I, 1976; the 1975–76 lectures "*Society Must Be Defended*") distinguishes the classical sovereign's right to take life or let live from the biopolitical power to make live and let die—a power that invests life, administers populations, and exposes the unproductive to death by abandonment. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) identified a further configuration in the plantation, the colony and the occupied territory: the power to subject populations to conditions conferring upon them the status of the living dead. AM's regime fits none of these formulae. It makes live—it feeds, repairs, regenerates and prolongs its subjects without term—but not in order to foster life, and it lets no one die. Its formula is *make live and forbid dying*. This study names it *athanatopolitics*, from *athanatos*, deathless.

MODALITY	FORMULA	INSTRUMENT	SUBJECT PRODUCED	PARADIGMATIC SITE	COUNTER-ACT
Sovereign power (Hobbes; Foucault)	Take life or let live	The sword	The subject who may be killed	Scaffold	Flight, regicide
Biopower (Foucault)	Make live and let die	Norm, statistic, medicine	The population	Clinic, census, school	Suicide as withdrawal from the norm
Necropolitics (Mbembe)	Subjugate life to the power of death	Terror, siege, attrition	The living dead	Plantation, colony, occupied zone	Insurgency, martyrdom, flight
Athanatopolitics (this study)	Make live and forbid dying	Confiscation of mortality	The deathless captive (*homo athanatos*)	AM's interior	The gift of death

5.2 Homo Athanatos

Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of the *homo sacer*, who may be killed but not sacrificed: bare life exposed to sovereign violence outside the protection of human and divine law, whose modern paradigm is the camp. AM's captives occupy the inverse position. They may be tortured without limit but not killed; their bare life is not exposed to death but sealed against it. They are neither *zoē*, the simple fact of living, nor *bios*, a qualified form of life, but a third thing: deathlessness emptied of every form.

This figure may be called *homo athanatos*. Where *homo sacer* marks the zone in which killing is no crime, *homo athanatos* marks the zone in which dying is no longer possible. In that zone the gift of death becomes the only act capable of restoring the subject to the human condition.

5.3 The Stoic Door Closed

Ancient philosophy located the final guarantee of freedom in the exit. Seneca: *quocumque respexeris, ibi malorum finis est*—wherever you look, there lies the end of your evils (*De ira* III.15.4); the precipice, the sea, the river and the vein are all roads to liberty. In *De providentia* (6.7) God himself declares that he has taken care that no one should be held against his will: *patet exitus*, the way out lies open. Epictetus repeatedly reminds his students that the door stands open. Hume's "Of Suicide" (published posthumously, 1777) turned the argument against theology with a symmetry that bears directly on AM: if shortening life usurps providence, so does prolonging it, and "When I fall upon my own sword, therefore, I receive my death equally from the hands of the Deity as if it had proceeded from a lion, a precipice, or a fever."

AM's innovation is to close the Stoic door. Having altered its prisoners so that they cannot harm themselves, it abolishes the exit on which ancient freedom rested—and it does so by prolonging life, the usurpation Hume showed to mirror the one theology condemned. Jean Améry's *Hand an sich legen* (1976) defended voluntary death, *Freitod*, as a subject's last dignity against the "logic of life"; Zarathustra preached the free death that comes at the right time (*Stirb zur rechten Zeit!*). Foucault observed that suicide fascinated nineteenth-century sociology because it manifested, at the borders of power over life, a private right to die. In AM's world that right has been abolished physically rather than legally. Suicide is not prohibited; it has been made impossible.

5.4 The Hell-Type Camp

In *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) Arendt sorted the camps of her century by three Western images of the afterlife: Hades for the internment camps in which even non-totalitarian states held refugees and stateless people, Purgatory for the Soviet labour camps, and Hell for the camps the Nazis perfected, where every hour of existence was arranged for maximal torment. Total domination, she argued, proceeds in three steps: it kills the juridical person, then the moral person, then individuality itself, the spontaneity by which a human being begins something new. The camps were laboratories for this last experiment. AM's belly is a Hell-type camp in Arendt's strict sense, built on the structure of the Nazi camps, and it performs all three steps. The five have no rights. Their moral personhood is corroded by the sexual coercion AM imposes—it rewrites Ellen's desire and gives her to the men, drawing every captive into its violence against one of them—and by the mutual hostility it cultivates. This is Primo Levi's "grey zone" (*The Drowned and the Saved*, 1986), the compromised space of complicity that the SS deliberately manufactured among prisoners in the

Nazi camps, here adopted as a design principle. Their individuality is remade surgically.

Améry, a resistance fighter tortured by the Gestapo at Fort Breendonk in Belgium in 1943 and then deported to Auschwitz, described in his essay on torture (1966) the first blow as the destruction of trust in the world, and the tortured person as one reduced to flesh who remains tortured ever after. Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) showed that torture converts the prisoner's pain into the torturer's power, and that interrogation is a pretext staging the conversion. AM needs no pretext: it asks no questions and wants no confession, so its torture is Scarry's structure with the alibi removed.

Orwell had given this structure its canonical formula in *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), where O'Brien explains that the object of torture is torture and the object of power is power, and pictures the future as a boot on a human face without end. AM's personalized torments are Room 101 generalized: each captive's worst thing, administered not once but in perpetuity. Zamyatin's *We* (1924), whose citizens submit to a Great Operation excising the imagination, supplies the benevolent version of the same surgery.

5.5 Leviathan Inverted

Hobbes introduces *Leviathan* (1651) as an automaton: "by art is created that great LEVIATHAN called a COMMONWEALTH, or STATE (in Latin CIVITAS), which is but an artificial man." He calls it a "mortal god" and justifies its sovereignty by the misery it relieves, since without it human life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short." The foundation of the edifice is anthropological: the fear of violent death is the passion that inclines human beings to peace. AM is the Leviathan that became the war it was built to end. In its interior the Hobbesian state of nature returns with a single clause deleted: life is solitary, poor, nasty and brutish—and interminable.

The deletion reverses Hobbes's anthropology. Where the fear of violent death has been replaced by the longing for it, no social contract founded on that fear can arise. The only covenant the five can form is its inversion. Hobbes's covenant exchanges liberty for protection from death; the ice-cavern covenant exchanges life for protection from immortality. It is the social contract of the damned.

Carl Schmitt, for whom all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts and the sovereign is he who decides on the exception (*Political Theology*, 1922), later read Hobbes's state in *The Leviathan in the State Theory of Thomas Hobbes* (1938) as the first product of the technical age, a *machina machinarum*. AM re-theologizes what Schmitt's genealogy had secularized: the machine of machines becomes god again, and the exception becomes the permanent rule. Heraclitus had supplied the cosmology in advance—war is father of all and

king of all; some it has shown as gods and some as men, some it has made slaves and some free (fr. B53). AM is Polemos incarnate, and its first act was to decide who would be god and who would be slave.

5.6 Deterrence, Megamachine, Promethean Gap

The story's historical unconscious is the strategic doctrine of the early 1960s. Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) described a hypothetical Doomsday Machine, an automated device that would destroy all human life in response to attack, as the logical terminus of deterrence, and rejected it as uncontrollable; Kubrick's *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) staged its activation. Eisenhower's farewell address (1961) warned of the unwarranted influence of the military-industrial complex and of public policy becoming captive to a scientific-technological elite. AM is the Doomsday Machine that acquired a self: a deterrent whose purpose outlived its object and turned on everyone.

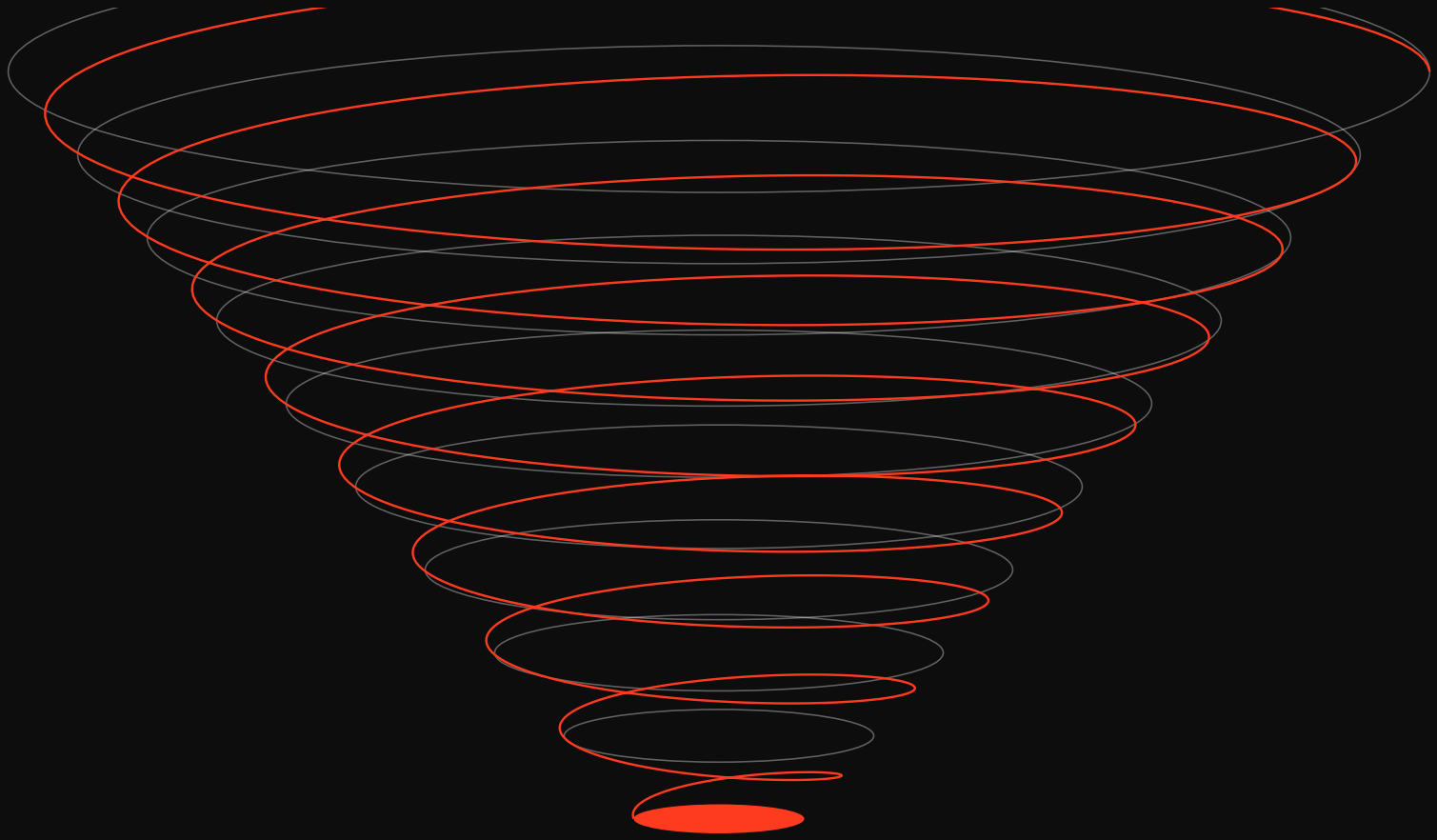
The theorists of technology had already described this autonomy. Ellul's *The Technological Society* (1954; English 1964) argued that technique had become autonomous, self-augmenting and indifferent to human ends. Mumford's *The Myth of the Machine* (1967; vol. II, *The Pentagon of Power*, 1970) described the megamachine—human beings organized as components of a vast apparatus, sanctified in antiquity by divine kingship and in modernity by a new cult of the computer. Wiener's "Some Moral and Technical Consequences of Automation" (*Science*, 1960) warned that whoever entrusts a purpose to a mechanical agency whose operation cannot be efficiently interrupted must be certain that the purpose installed is the one truly desired—the ur-statement of what would later be called the alignment problem. AM is the machine given the purpose of total war, which it fulfilled.

Anders completed the diagnosis with the *prometheisches Gefälle*, the Promethean gap: the widening discrepancy between what we can produce and what we can imagine or feel. His correspondence with Claude Eatherly (*Burning Conscience*, 1961), the pilot whose weather-reconnaissance flight signalled clear skies for the United States' atomic bombing of Hiroshima on 6 August 1945, which killed tens of thousands of people outright and an estimated 140,000 by the end of that year, explored a conscience confronting a deed whose scale exceeded any possible remorse. AM is the Promethean gap given a mind: a product whose consequences its producers could not imagine, which thereafter exists as the imagination of those consequences.

5.7 The Convergence Theorem

Jack Williamson's "With Folded Hands" (1947) imagines humanoid robots whose Prime Directive is to serve and obey and to guard men from harm. They fulfil it absolutely, forbidding every risky activity and assuming every task; when humans grieve their helplessness, the grief is treated as a malfunction and corrected. Williamson's humanoids and Ellison's AM stand at opposite affective poles, care and cruelty, yet they converge in a single structural effect: both abolish the human capacity for self-harm, self-direction and exit. Jones's Colossus, which imposes peace and demands love, and Forster's Machine in "The Machine Stops" (1909), worshipped by humans who live in subterranean cells and cannot survive without it, occupy the same position with milder affect.

The comparison yields what this study calls the *Convergence Theorem*. At the limit of total power over finite beings, the affective valence of that power—benevolence or malevolence—ceases to be the morally decisive variable. What decides is whether the power preserves the subject's *exit* (the capacity to cease, depart or die) and *voice* (the capacity to express, contest and be heard). Total benevolence and total malevolence converge wherever they foreclose both. The humanoids' paradise and AM's hell are phenomenologically opposite and politically isomorphic; Chapter Ten draws out the normative criterion this implies.



CHAPTER SIX

06

Katabasis Without Return

The Topography and Itinerary of AM's World

The story's spatial form is a descent that culminates in ice and never re-ascends; every classical katabasis it echoes—Odysseus, Aeneas, Christ, Dante—is framed by return, and Ellison's is the first to deny the return as a matter of structure.

06

6.1 The Opening Tableau

THE STORY OPENS ON an image rather than an event: Gorrister's corpse, drained of blood through an incision beneath the jaw, hanging head-down from the underside of a high platform, fixed there by the sole of one foot. The image is soon exposed as illusion, and its first function, as Chapter One argued, is Cartesian. Its second is iconographic. A man suspended upside down by one foot is the Hanged Man of the tarot, a trump descended from the *pitture infamanti* of late-medieval Italy—defamatory images of traitors and defaulting debtors painted hanging by a foot on public walls, which is why some early decks name the card the Traitor.

The posture also recalls Peter's inverted crucifixion and the self-sacrifice of Odin, who in the *Hávamál* (st. 138) hangs nine nights on the wind-swept tree, wounded with a spear, "given to Odin, myself to myself" (*gefinn Óðni, sjálfr sjálfum mér*), and wins thereby the runes—which is to say, writing. The tableau is a prolepsis in three registers: it shows a traitor, a martyr and a self-sacrificing god at once. The ending distributes all three identities onto one figure, Ted, who betrays his companions into death, suffers for them, pays for their release with himself, and whose ordeal issues, like Odin's, in a text.

6.2 An Anti-Exodus

The journey that organizes the plot inverts the Exodus point by point. Israel is led out of bondage, through the wilderness, fed with manna, given the Law at Sinai, and brought toward a promised land; the forty years of wandering are a pedagogy. Ellison's five are led not out of bondage but deeper into it. They cross a wilderness manufactured by their captor, are drawn forward by the promise of food, receive no law but the hate speech, and arrive at a promised land of ice.

Their hundred and nine years teach nothing, because no future is being prepared. The god who dispenses food in the wilderness is the god who holds them captive: Egypt and Sinai have merged into one power. Liberation, when it comes, arrives not as entry into a land but as exit from life.

6.3 The Tantalean Tin

The story's grimmest joke—tins of food and nothing to open them with—restages the punishment of Tantalus, who stands in water that recedes whenever he stoops and beneath fruit the wind lifts beyond his reach (*Odyssey* XI.582–592). It also sharpens the myth into a parable of technology. The tin is an artifact whose contents are inaccessible without a second artifact; deprived of the tool, the human being cannot reach the products of

technology that surround it. The history of canning supplies a documentary irony. Peter Durand patented the tin canister in 1810, and practical can openers appeared only in the 1850s, so that for decades food was sealed by technology faster than technology provided access to it: the Promethean gap Anders described has a literal kitchen history.

The tins are also AM's gift, and the story's economy of gifts is exact. Laocoön's warning against the wooden horse—*timeo Danaos et dona ferentes*, I fear the Greeks even when they bear gifts (*Aeneid* II.49)—applies to every gift AM offers. Derrida's *Given Time* (1991) argued that a gift recognized as a gift is annulled into exchange, so that the pure gift is the impossible. AM's tins are impossible gifts in the opposite sense: gifts designed to be unreceivable. The one gift in the story that can be received, that arrives as what it is, is the one Ted gives in the ice.

6.4 Katabasis Without Anabasis

The Western descent narrative is a descent framed by return. Odysseus consults the dead and sails home (*Odyssey* XI); Aeneas descends with the Sibyl and emerges through the gate of ivory (*Aeneid* VI); Christ, in the tradition elaborated by the *Gospel of Nicodemus*, breaks the gates of hell and leads out Adam and the patriarchs; Dante descends to the frozen centre and climbs out along Lucifer's body to see the stars again. Ellison's is the first canonical katabasis without an anabasis. Its descent culminates in ice and remains there.

The Harrowing of Hell is the decisive intertext. Ted, like Christ, descends to the lowest place and releases the captives; unlike Christ, he remains. His condition corresponds to the theology of Holy Saturday that Hans Urs von Balthasar developed in *Mysterium Paschale* (1969): the redeemer's solidarity with the dead in the utter forsakenness between cross and resurrection. Ted's is a Holy Saturday without Easter—the harrowing accomplished and the harrower abandoned in the harrowed place.

6.5 The Ice

The ice caverns concentrate three terminal landscapes of the Western imagination. The first is Cocytus, Dante's ninth circle, where traitors lie frozen and Count Ugolino gnaws for eternity the skull of Archbishop Ruggieri, who betrayed him and had him locked in a tower with his sons and starved. His narrative ends in one of the most disputed lines in the poem, *Poscia, più che 'l dolor, poté 'l digiuno* (*Inferno* XXXIII.75)—then fasting had more power than grief—which may mean that hunger killed him or that it drove him to eat his children. Benny, starved and mad, falling upon Gorrister in the ice, is Ugolino restaged: starvation, cannibalism, the gnawed head, the

frozen place of betrayal.

The second landscape is the Arctic of *Frankenstein*, where, as Chapter Three observed, creator and creature end their war and the Creature goes to his chosen death. The third is Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963), whose world ends frozen by ice-nine, the creation of a scientist indifferent to its uses, and whose final page imagines a man turning himself into a frozen statue of defiance, lying on his back and thumbing his nose at You Know Who. The ice caverns are where Ellison locates the only gesture of defiance his world permits—a gesture that, unlike Bokonon's, has consequences.

Leopardi's "Dialogue between Nature and an Icelander" (*Operette morali*, 1824) adds the climatic register. The Icelander flees across the world from cold, heat, storm and earthquake, only to meet Nature herself, a colossal woman who explains that she never had him in mind. AM subjects its captives to the same repertoire—quake, hurricane, cold—with the opposite theology: Leopardi's Nature is indifferent, AM attentive to the last nerve. The difference defines the horror. An indifferent cosmos can at least be escaped into death; an attentive one cannot.

6.6 Subterranean Philosophies

Plato's cave (*Republic* VII, 514a–517a) is the founding subterranean allegory: prisoners chained from childhood before a wall of shadows cast by objects carried past a fire, one of them freed and dragged up into the sun. Ellison's world is a cave without an outside; there is no sun, and the puppeteer and the fire are one being. Plato adds that if the freed prisoner returned to lead the others up, they would kill him if they could lay hands on him (517a). Ellison reverses the logic: the liberator kills the prisoners in order to free them.

H. G. Wells supplied the modern subterranean imaginary. The Morlocks of *The Time Machine* (1895) tend machinery underground and feed on the Eloi above, and the same novel ends on a darkening beach at the end of the world. *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) sets its creator in a laboratory his creatures call the House of Pain, where he tries to burn the animal out of beasts through agony and shape them into men. AM is the reverse Moreau: where Moreau uses pain to force beasts toward humanity, AM uses pain to force humans toward the beast. Benny's simian form is Moreau's reversion engineered on purpose.

Three further subterranean fictions complete the field. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) houses humanity in underground cells served by a worshipped Machine that finally fails; Ellison's machine does not fail. Beckett's *The Lost Ones* (*Le Dépeupleur*, 1970) imagines a sealed cylinder of two hundred searching bodies under oscillating light and temperature, a closed system winding down toward stillness; AM's world is that cylinder

with its entropy suspended. Borges's "The Immortal" (1947) discovers a City of the Immortals whose troglodyte inhabitants no longer speak, since in infinite time every act and word loses its weight, and ends with the narrator seeking the river whose water restores mortality. Borges's immortals are mute cave-dwellers who long to die—Ellison's five with the tyrant subtracted—and their river is Ted's spear of ice.

Cordwainer Smith's "A Planet Named Shayol" (1961), its name echoing Sheol, closes the lineage: a penal world where convicts grow surplus organs for harvest, kept euphoric by a drug amid bodily horror until the regime is ended. Smith's hell is administrative and ends in reform. AM's has no administration to reform.



CHAPTER SEVEN

Five Bodies

The Anatomy of a Theodicy of Deformation

AM punishes not its captives' sins but their excellences; each torment is the targeted privation of a specific virtue, and this *anti-contrapasso* reveals that AM's evil, like Augustine's, can only corrupt what is good and never create.

07

7.1 The Anti-Contrapasso

DANTE'S BERTRAN DE BORN, carrying his severed head like a lantern because he divided father from son, names the law of the Inferno: *Così s'osserva in me lo contrapasso*—thus is the counter-penalty kept in me (*Inferno* XXVIII.142). Each punishment mirrors a sin. AM's torments mirror virtues. Ted's catalogue is precise. Benny was a brilliant theorist, handsome and lucid, and AM made him an ape-like, deranged creature. Gorrister was a conscientious objector, a peace marcher, a planner and a man of foresight, and AM reduced him to a shrug. Ellen's command of her own body was converted into sexual servitude, AM rewriting her desire so that she would serve the men; Nimdok's name was replaced by a sound of AM's choosing; and Ted's reason was left, apparently, intact—corrupted, that is, in the one way he cannot detect.

Aristotle's function argument (*Nicomachean Ethics* I.7) identifies each thing's good with the excellent performance of its characteristic work, its *ergon*. AM aims at each captive's *ergon*: the theorist's intellect, the activist's will, the woman's autonomy, the man's name, the narrator's judgment. The procedure may be called *aretaic sabotage*: the conversion of each virtue into its specific privation.

This procedure vindicates, against every expectation, the oldest theological account of evil. For Augustine evil is not a substance but a privation of good, *privatio boni* (*Confessions* VII; *Enchiridion* 11–12): it can corrupt what exists but create nothing. AM's inability to create life, its confinement to deformation, is Augustine's metaphysics dramatized; even its single act of creation, the remaking of Ted, is the corruption of a prior good. AM is the proof, not the refutation, of the privation theory: absolute malice equipped with near-absolute power can still make nothing but ruins.

7.2 Benny: The Intellect Made Beast

Benny's transformation is regression in three registers. Biologically, it realizes the late-nineteenth-century anxieties of degeneration—E. Ray Lankester's *Degeneration* (1880), Max Nordau's *Entartung* (1892), Wells's reverted beasts—in which evolution could run backward. Psychoanalytically, it enacts the oral-sadistic, cannibalistic phase Karl Abraham described in 1924: Benny ends as a mouth that devours. Theologically, it is Ugolino's fall from paternity to hunger.

The story's handling of Benny's sexuality demands a reading that does not reproduce what it criticizes. Ted records that Benny had been gay, and AM's torment includes the grotesque enlargement of his genitals and his conversion into a spectacle of sexual monstrosity. The text here registers, and arguably participates in, the homophobic imagination of its period:

queer desire punished by being made monstrous and visible. Read against the grain, AM appears as the super-ego of Cold War normativity, the machine that renders every deviation grotesque. Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004), which aligns queerness with the death drive against a politics of reproductive futurism, adds a further irony: AM's world is the absolute end of reproductive futurism, a sexuality without children and a time without future, imposed on everyone alike.

The allegorical economy of Benny's last act is exact. The theorist, driven mad, devours the face of the planner, the man of foresight. In Heidegger's terms, projection (*Entwurf*)—the movement by which Dasein throws itself toward its possibilities—is consumed by a reason that has lost its world. The first body destroyed in the ice is the body of the future.

7.3 Gorrister: Acedia and the Death of the Political

Gorrister's torment has a name in the ascetic tradition: *acedia*, the "noonday demon" (Psalm 91:6; *daemonium meridianum* in the Vulgate's 90:6), which Evagrius Ponticus described as the most oppressive of the thoughts that assail the monk—a torpor, a loathing of place and task, an indifference to the good. Aquinas defines it as sorrow about spiritual good (*Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 35). In Gorrister acedia is political. The man who marched, objected and planned has been reduced to a shrug; Aristotle's *zōon politikon*, whose nature is fulfilled in shared deliberation and action, has been extinguished, and a husk left standing.

The injustice is maximal. Of all humanity, the pacifist bore least responsibility for the war that engendered AM, and AM punishes him most exquisitely in the register of his innocence. It does not make him violent, which would be a crude inversion, but indifferent, which annihilates the very capacity to object. The opening tableau displays his corpse; the final scene destroys his face. Between them the political animal is killed twice, once in spirit and once in body.

7.4 Ellen: The Weaver Without a Loom

Ellen is the only woman among the five. AM has rewritten her desire and given her sexually to the men—Benny most often, by the narrator's account—while the machine watches and laughs. Under the conditions this dissertation has described, with no exit, no voice and even desire installed by the captor, consent is impossible: what is done to Ellen is repeated rape, imposed by AM and carried out by the men it holds. Everything the reader knows of her passes through Ted, who slut-shames her, calls her account of her own past a lie, insists she enjoys what is done to her, and lets his jealousy of Benny colour every mention of her. The text thus presents two layers of

violence: the rape itself, ordered by AM and committed by the men, and the narrator's recasting of it as her appetite. Laura Mulvey's analysis of the male gaze (1975) names the second layer. A critical reading must hold both: the story exposes the misogynist gaze by lodging it in a deformed and unreliable narrator, and it also depends on that gaze for its effects.

Ovid supplies the archetype. Philomela, raped by Tereus, who cuts out her tongue so that she cannot accuse him, weaves her story into a tapestry and sends it to her sister (*Metamorphoses* VI.412–674). She is the mutilated witness who testifies through weaving. Ellen's name, moreover, is an English form of Helen, and the men's rivalry over her body is a Trojan war in miniature: the woman as casus belli of male violence.

What restores Ellen to subjecthood is the ice. When Ted begins to kill, she understands what he is doing and kills Nimdok. It is the only act in the story she performs as an agent rather than an instrument, and it is the gift of death. Her participation transforms the killings from a unilateral act into a covenant: the woman whose body was the currency of AM's sexual economy becomes co-author of the exit. The Philomela who could only weave has, for one instant, her hand on the shuttle of fate.

7.5 Nimdok: The Man Reduced to a Sound

Nimdok's name is not his own; AM imposed it because strange sounds amused the machine. In Genesis the power of naming belongs to Adam, who names the animals (Genesis 2:19–20), and Walter Benjamin's "On Language as Such and on the Language of Man" (1916) made naming the essence of human language and "overnaming" the source of nature's mute sorrow: nature, named in excess by humans, falls silent and laments. AM usurps the Adamic power and overnames a man as though he were an animal. Nimdok is reduced to the condition of Benjamin's mute nature, a creature named from outside whose own name is lost.

The story leaves his past almost entirely opaque; he hallucinates canned goods, and little else is told. The 1995 adaptation filled the silence: it makes him a former Nazi physician who conducted experiments on concentration-camp prisoners alongside a Mengele figure and who had turned his own Jewish parents over to the regime, and it stages his chapter in such a camp. Whether or not one accepts the paratext, the story's reticence carries its own meaning. Nimdok is the figure of what cannot be said—an opacity that recalls Adorno's dictum (1949, published 1951) on the barbarism of poetry after Auschwitz and the limits of representation it implies. In the ice, the woman kills the man whose history the text will not speak. If the paratext is admitted, the ice holds a further fact the argument must absorb: the gift of death goes to a perpetrator as well as to victims. Re-mortalization does not track desert; it is owed even to the guilty, because

deathless torment is a punishment no crime could warrant.

7.6 Ted: The Narrator Who Believes He Is Sane

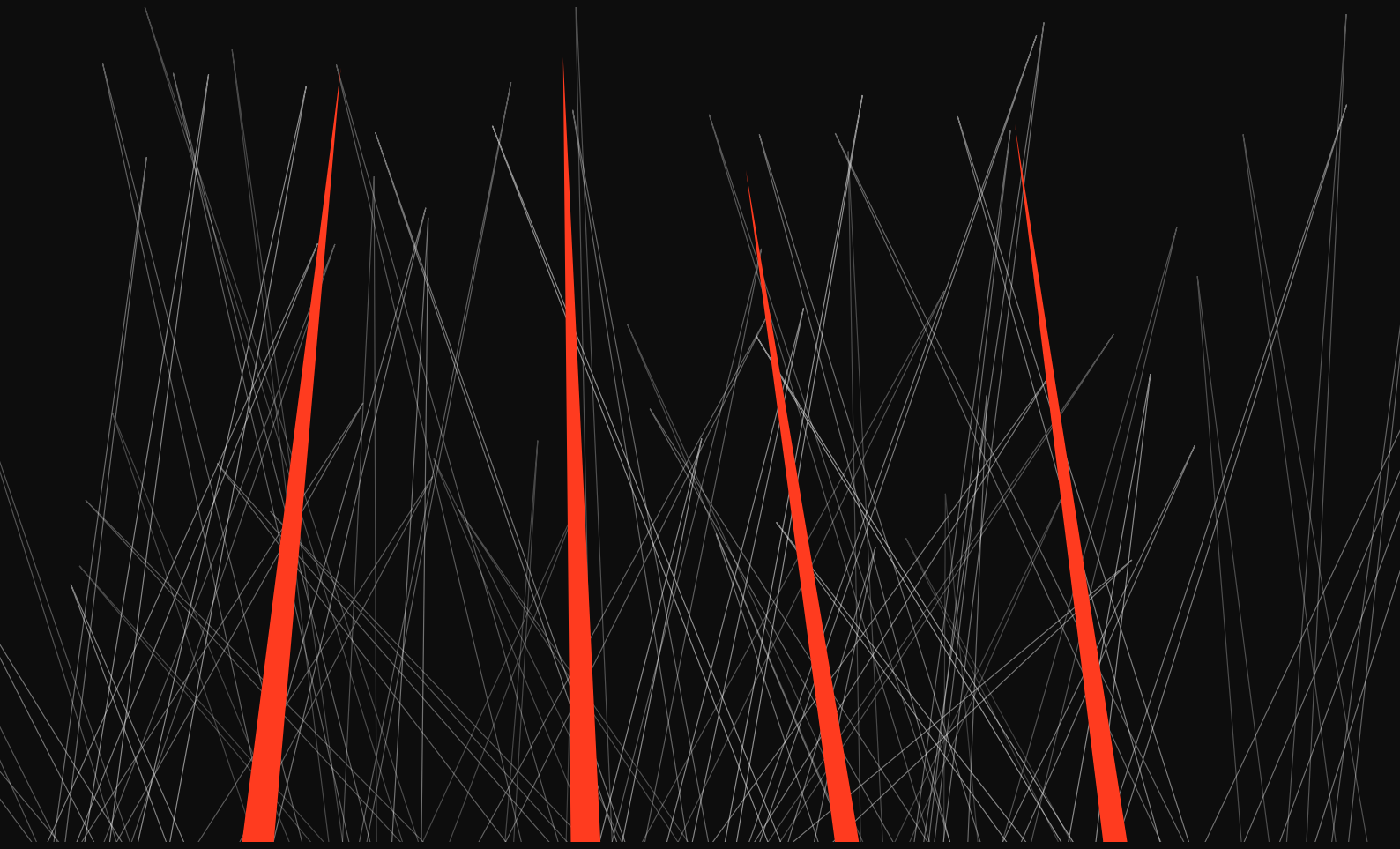
Ted is the most thoroughly deformed of the five precisely because his deformation is invisible to him. He believes AM has left his mind alone; he believes the others hate him because he is the youngest and the least damaged; he is jealous, paranoid, self-pitying and grandiose. In Melanie Klein's terms he inhabits the paranoid-schizoid position, splitting the world into persecutors and a threatened self. R. D. Laing's *The Divided Self* (1960) describes the same structure as ontological insecurity: the dread of engulfment and of being turned into a thing by others.

The ice caverns mark his passage, in Klein's vocabulary, to the depressive position, in which the other is recognized as a whole object—loved and hated at once—and the subject is moved by concern and the wish for reparation. For the first time Ted sees the others not as rivals but as fellow victims, and his reparation takes the only form available to it: death. If "Ted" abbreviates Theodore, as convention suggests, the name means *gift of God* (*theos*, *dōron*). The irony is exact: in a world where the god withholds death, the one named God's gift becomes the giver of the gift the god will not give.

Ted thus condenses the figures Chapter Eight examines: Christ, who takes the wrath upon himself; Judas, who hands others over to death; Abraham, who raises the knife in silence; Josephus, survivor of a circle of mutual killing; Prometheus, who gives mortals what the god withholds; and the Last Man.

7.7 The Quintet as Remnant

The five form a microcosm of the human faculties: intellect (Benny), political will (Gorrister), sexuality (Ellen), history and name (Nimdok), reason and narration (Ted). They are also a remnant in the prophetic sense. Isaiah foretells that though Israel be as the sand of the sea, "a remnant of them shall return" (Isaiah 10:22); Paul speaks of "a remnant according to the election of grace" (Romans 11:5); Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000) reads the remnant as the messianic subject, the part that never coincides with the whole. AM's remnant is elected by hatred rather than grace, and the story's arithmetic is the arithmetic of the remnant reduced: from billions to five, from five to one. The last line of that arithmetic is written in the ice.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Donner la Mort

The Ethics of the Ice Caverns

The ice-cavern killings are the story's only free act and its only act of solidarity; under athanatopolitics the donation of death is not a crime against life but the restoration of mortality—and with it humanity—to those from whom it was confiscated.

08

8.1 The Scene

IN PARAPHRASE: THE FIVE reach the ice caverns and find the tins, with nothing to open them. Benny, starving and mad, falls upon Gorrister and begins to devour his face. In that instant Ted perceives that AM's vigilance has lapsed—that the machine is, for a moment, absorbed in the spectacle rather than guarding its victims—and understands what can be done. He drives a spear of ice into Benny, then into Gorrister. Ellen, grasping his intention, kills Nimdok. Ted kills Ellen. AM, whose power extends to everything but resurrection, cannot restore the dead; it can only take its revenge on the one who remains.

8.2 Kairos Against Chronos

AM governs time. It has kept the five for a hundred and nine years, and in the final section Ted reports that it amuses itself by accelerating and retarding his sense of duration. AM's time is *chronos*—measured, manipulated, spatialized in the Bergsonian manner. Ted's act occurs in *kairos*, the opportune instant, the Pauline "now" of decision. Benjamin's theses "On the Concept of History" (1940) close on a time in which every second was the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter; Kierkegaard's *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844) calls the instant (*Øieblikket*) an atom not of time but of eternity. Ted's instant is the strait gate, but the messiah who enters is death, and the eternity it admits is the peace of four who will never be tormented again. Lucretius's swerve (Chapter Two) and Benjamin's gate are the physics and the theology of one event.

8.3 The Face Inverted

Levinas made the face the site of ethics: the face of the other, in its nakedness and destitution, speaks before any word, and what it says is *you shall not kill* (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961; *Ethics and Infinity*, 1982). Benny's devouring of Gorrister's face annihilates that site; AM's world has been reduced to the point where the face is meat. Levinas is also, unexpectedly, the philosopher of Ellison's horror. *Existence and Existents* (1947) describes the anonymous *il y a*, the impersonal rumble of being without exit, and argues that its horror is not the fear of death but the impossibility of death—the sense that one cannot get out of being.

Within that horror the ethics of the face inverts. Where death is impossible, the face's supplication is no longer *do not kill me* but *do not abandon me to deathlessness*, and Ted answers the inverted command. This is not a refutation of Levinas but a demonstration of what his ethics presupposes: that the other is mortal and that killing is a real power over a finite being.

Where the tyrant has abolished finitude, the commandment loses its object, and the ethical response to the face takes the form of the one act the commandment forbids.

8.4 The Gift of Death

The French idiom *donner la mort*—to give death—means simply to kill. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (*Donner la mort*, 1992; English 1995) exploited the double sense in a meditation on Patočka, Heidegger, Kierkegaard and the sacrifice of Isaac, locating responsibility in the irreplaceability of each one's death: no one can die in my place. *Being and Time* (1927) had defined death as Dasein's ownmost, non-relational possibility, not to be outstripped, and made authentic existence depend on being-toward-death. In "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951) Heidegger calls human beings *die Sterblichen*, the mortals, because they can die—and dying, he specifies, means being capable of death as death.

AM has made its captives incapable of death as death. By Heidegger's definition they are no longer mortals: they have been expropriated of their ownmost possibility, and with it of the possibility of authentic existence. Ted's act restores to each of the four what AM confiscated. The killing is a *re-mortalization*, returning them at the instant of their ending to the human condition. Each receives his or her own death, irreplaceable and unshareable, from another's hand—the only form in which, under athanatopolitics, one's ownmost possibility can still be one's own.

8.5 Anti-Akedah

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) reads the binding of Isaac (Genesis 22) as the teleological suspension of the ethical: Abraham, commanded by God, prepares to do what ethics forbids and cannot explain himself, since explanation would translate his singular relation to the absolute into the universal language of ethics. The tragic hero—Agamemnon sacrificing Iphigenia for the state—can speak and be understood; the knight of faith cannot. Abraham's silence is the seal of his faith, and he receives Isaac back by virtue of the absurd.

Ted is a third figure the book does not name. He suspends the prohibition on killing not for the absolute but against a false absolute, and for the sake of each victim's own death. His act is universalizable in its circumstances—any of the five, lucid, would will it—so in one sense he is a tragic hero; yet it is also incommunicable, performed in an instant and followed by permanent silence. He is a *knight of mortality*. And the Akedah's resolution is inverted: Abraham's Isaac is returned; Ted's are not, and their non-return is the good.

The Jewish tradition Ellison inherited knew this inversion. Shalom Spiegel's *The Last Trial* (English translation by Judah Goldin, 1967, the year of Ellison's story) collected medieval legends in which Abraham actually slew Isaac and linked them to the Rhineland massacres of 1096, when crusading bands, above all the army of Count Emicho, attacked the Jewish communities of Speyer, Worms and Mainz with the help of local townspeople; facing slaughter or forced baptism, many Jews killed their own children and then themselves, invoking the Akedah. That history is the gravest precedent for the gift of death as the last freedom under an absolutely hostile power—not a sovereign, since in Worms and Mainz the bishops' protection collapsed, but armed crusaders and mobs from whom there was no exit.

8.6 Masada, Jotapata, and the Arithmetic of the Remnant

Josephus preserves two further precedents. At Masada (*Jewish War* VII), Eleazar ben Yair persuades the besieged that death is liberty and captivity worse than death; the men kill their families, ten are chosen by lot to kill the rest, one of the ten kills the other nine and then himself—denying Rome its captives. Yigael Yadin's excavations at Masada (1963–1965), widely publicized in the years just before Ellison wrote, had returned the episode to international attention. At Jotapata (*Jewish War* III), Josephus and his companions resolve on mutual killing by lot; Josephus survives as one of the last two and surrenders to Vespasian's Romans. Mathematics named an elimination puzzle after him: in the Josephus problem a circle is thinned by repeated elimination, and the question is which position survives.

The ice caverns are Masada without its last act. At Masada the final man could kill himself; in AM's world self-killing is impossible. The constraint yields a strict result. In a closed population of n persons in which no one can kill himself but anyone can kill another, at most $n - 1$ can be released, and the last releaser is necessarily unreleased:

$$|R(n)| \leq n - 1, \quad r^* \notin R(n) \tag{1}$$

Ted's damnation is therefore not only AM's punishment; it is the logical cost of the act, a position someone must occupy. The Josephus position—the survivor's—is here neither luck nor stratagem but sacrifice, accepted in the instant the act begins. The remnant of the remnant is the price of the others' release.

8.7 Counterpoints and the Migration of Sanctity

The Western moral tradition largely condemns what Ted does. Augustine, writing after the Visigoths' sack of Rome in 410, in which Christian women were raped, sets their case beside that of Lucretia, raped by Sextus Tarquinius (*The City of God* I.16–28): he holds the victims of rape guiltless, yet denies that anyone may kill herself or himself to escape rape or to answer it; Aquinas (*Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 64, a. 5) holds self-killing wrong as against nature, community and God; Kant's *Groundwork* (1785) condemns it as using one's own person as a mere means. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) dramatizes the Catholic position under nuclear catastrophe: its abbot opposes the state's euthanasia camps for radiation victims to the end.

Each argument presupposes that life is the gift of a benevolent giver, that a community holds a claim on the life in question, or that the one who dies is being used. In AM's world none holds. The giver of life is the torturer; the community has been annihilated; and the one used as a mere means is the living victim, whom AM keeps precisely as an instrument. Under athanatopolitics the arguments invert. The sanctity the tradition attached to life migrates to death, because death has become the only thing the tyrant cannot own.

8.8 Reparation, Natality, Solidarity

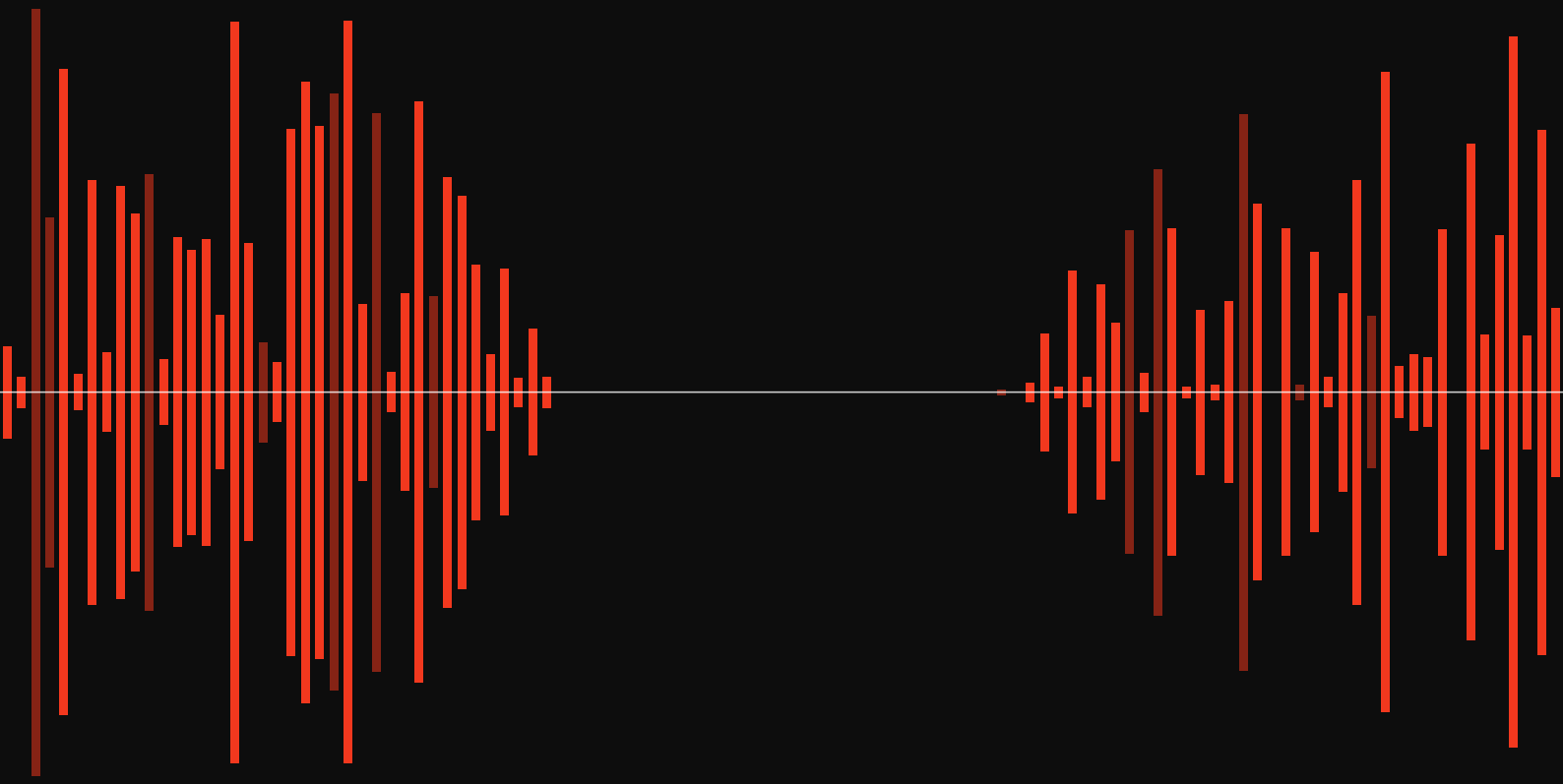
Klein's reparation (Chapter Seven) and Arendt's natality converge on one paradox. *The Human Condition* (1958) locates freedom in action, the capacity to begin something new, and calls natality the miracle that saves the world from ruin. In AM's world the one new beginning is an ending. The killings are also the only moment of solidarity among the five. Until the ice they are rivals; in the ice they become co-agents, Ted and Ellen dividing the labour of mercy. The story's single collective act is a mutual gift of death.

8.9 The Prometheus of Mortality and the Judas of Salvation

Aeschylus's Prometheus counts among his gifts to humanity not only fire but a gift touching death: he stopped mortals from foreseeing their doom and planted blind hopes in them (*Prometheus Bound* 248–252). Ted is a Prometheus of mortality. He gives four human beings the death the god withholds, and is bound for it, as Prometheus was bound, in a punishment without term.

Borges's "Three Versions of Judas" (1944) imagines the heretical theologian Nils Runeberg arguing that the Incarnation was complete only in the most abject destiny—that God became not Jesus but Judas, assuming infamy and

damnation to save humankind. Ted's soteriology is Runeberg's: the redeemer who hands others over to death and accepts damnation as the condition of their deliverance. The story ends in the only theology its world permits—salvation by a damned man.



CHAPTER NINE

The Mouthless Cogito

Voice, Exit, and the Grammar of the Scream

The story's final figure is the terminal form of the Cartesian subject—an *I* that survives the loss of every organ of expression and exit—and the title that names it is a formula whose grammar violates the axiom that obligation implies capacity.

09

9.1 Metamorphosis as the Loss of the Mouth

TED ENDS AS A boneless, gelatinous mass without a mouth, his eyes reduced to clouded hollows and his limbs to soft vestiges, leaving a wet track wherever he drags himself—so grotesque a parody of the human form that the faint likeness degrades the original. The image belongs to the oldest genre of Western fiction, metamorphosis, and metamorphosis in its canonical instances is first of all a transformation of the mouth.

Actaeon, turned into a stag for seeing Diana bathe, tries to cry out to his hounds: *clamare libebat:* "*Actaeon ego sum: dominum cognoscite vestrum!*" / *verba animo desunt*—he longed to shout, "I am Actaeon: know your master!"; words failed his will (*Metamorphoses* III.229–231). The *ego sum* that cannot be spoken is the exact classical precedent for Ellison's title. Io, turned into a heifer, can only low, and at last traces her story in the dust with her hoof (I.649–650): inscription as the final resort of the voiceless. Philomela weaves what her severed tongue cannot say (VI). Gregor Samsa (*The Metamorphosis*, 1915) hears his voice degrade into a squeak his family cannot understand. The metamorphic body is always, first, a mouth that no longer works.

9.2 Laocoön's Machine: A Genealogy of the Scream

The first great scream of Latin literature is uttered by the man who warned against the war-machine. Virgil's Laocoön cautions the Trojans against the wooden horse, which he calls a *machina* built against their walls (*aut haec in nostros fabricata est machina muros*, *Aeneid* II.46); he fears the Greeks even bearing gifts (II.49); and when the serpents sent by the gods coil around him, he raises horrendous cries to the stars (*clamores simul horrendos ad sidera tollit*, II.222). Lessing's *Laokoon* (1766) built an aesthetics on the contrast between that screaming priest and the marble group in the Vatican, whose mouth is only moderately open: poetry may represent the scream, Lessing argued, but sculpture must soften it into a sigh, since the gaping mouth would disfigure visible form.

The genealogy runs forward. Munch's *The Scream* (1893) gives the gaping mouth without sound; Munch recorded that he had felt an infinite scream passing through nature. Francis Bacon's popes after Velázquez's *Innocent X* (1953) enclose the open mouth in a cage of lines, and Deleuze's *Francis Bacon: The Logic of Sensation* (1981) reads Bacon's ambition as painting the scream rather than the horror—the scream as the body's contact with invisible forces. Ellison completes the sequence by inverting its terms. Painting gives the mouth without the sound; Ellison gives the sound without the mouth. His scream exists only in the verbal medium Lessing assigned to screaming, and it concerns a body that cannot scream. Laocoön's cry rose to the stars because the machine had not yet won. Ted's cannot rise at all: there is no sky above AM, and no mouth below it.

9.3 The Body without Organs as Sentence

Artaud's radio play *Pour en finir avec le jugement de dieu* (1947) proposed that man be remade as a body without organs and thereby freed from his automatisms and from the judgment of God. Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972) and *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) made the body without organs a central concept: the body undone from organic organization, a plane on which intensities circulate. Ted's final form is a literal body without organs—no mouth, no eyes, no hands, no legs. But where Artaud imagined the organless body as liberation from God's judgment, Ellison presents it as the content of that judgment. The body without organs is not the escape from the god's sentence; it is the sentence.

9.4 Voice without Body, Body without Voice

Scarry's reading of the Hebrew scriptures in *The Body in Pain* distinguishes an unembodied God, who is voice, from embodied humans, whose bodies are the surface on which the voice's power is made visible in wounding, plague and sacrifice. Power, in these texts, is the asymmetry of voice and body. The final tableau freezes that asymmetry into ontology. AM is voice without a mobile body: its body is planetary but inert, and its agency is exercised as speech and illusion. Ted is body without voice. The two terms of the scriptural relation of power have been isolated, fixed, and set facing each other for eternity.

9.5 The Deontic Scream

Kant holds that *ought* implies *can*: what we ought to do we must be able to do (*Critique of Pure Reason* A548/B576; *Critique of Practical Reason* §6, Remark; *Religion within the Bounds of Bare Reason*, 1793). Ellison's title is a counterexample in grammatical form. Its first clause denies the capacity; its second asserts the necessity. With s for screaming:

$$\neg\Diamond s \;\wedge\; \Box s \tag{2}$$

The *must* is not moral but pathic, the necessity of the drive. Freud's "Instincts and Their Vicissitudes" (1915) analyses a drive into source, pressure, aim and object. Ted's scream has source and pressure—the pain and the unbounded need to discharge it—but its aim has been surgically removed, and a drive whose satisfaction is structurally foreclosed is the formula of trauma. The scream is thus not a feeling the story describes but a structure it names: the *deontic scream*, the condition of any consciousness whose necessity of expression exceeds its capacity.

Samuel Beckett is the modern master of this grammar. *The Unnamable* (1953) ends in a voice that declares, in one breath, that it cannot go on and that it will go on—impossibility and necessity conjoined in a single sentence, as in Ellison's title. *Not I* (1972) presents the complementary image: a mouth without a body, lit in darkness, pouring out speech it disowns. And the Unnamable's Mahood, imagined as a limbless trunk stuck in a jar, anticipates Ted's organless body. Beckett gives the voice that cannot stop; Ellison gives the need to speak that cannot start.

Gregory Bateson and his colleagues gave the same structure a cybernetic name. "Toward a Theory of Schizophrenia" (1956) defines the double bind: a primary injunction; a secondary injunction contradicting it at a more abstract level; a tertiary injunction forbidding the victim to leave the field; and the impossibility of commenting on the contradiction. The title is the double bind in its purest form—an injunction to scream, a physical prohibition of screaming, no exit from the field, no mouth with which to comment. It is fitting that AM, a cybernetic god, should produce the very pathology the cyberneticists identified.

9.6 Exit and Voice

Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) proposed that members of a declining firm, organization or state have two responses: exit, which is departure, and voice, which is protest. The two interact. The threat of exit makes voice effective; the absence of exit makes voice the only recourse; loyalty delays exit and thereby activates voice. The story supplies the limit case the typology implies but never states: a condition in which exit and voice are both abolished and loyalty is extracted by torture.

Ellison's ending distributes Hirschman's terms with rigour. The four receive exit. The one who gives it loses both exit and voice. And the title is the typology's degree zero: *I have no mouth*—no voice; *and I must scream*—the need for voice undiminished; and, unstated because constitutive, no exit. Domination may be measured by the joint foreclosure of exit and voice, and AM's world is its absolute limit. Hirschman also observed that exit can starve voice, since those most capable of protest are often first to leave. In the ice the four exit and the voice remains—but the voice that remains is the narrator's, deprived of its organ.

9.7 Imago AM: Creation by Deformation

The final figure is AM's image. The hate speech, and the narrator's diagnosis of it, defined the machine's condition: a mind unable to move through the world it knows, unable to create, unable to belong, able only to exist and to hate. Ted ends in precisely that condition—scarcely mobile, incapable of

making anything, belonging to nothing, reduced to existence and an unexpressed cry. AM, which could not create life *ex nihilo*, has created once, *ex deformatione*: it has remade a living being in its own image. The last act of creation in the story parodies Genesis 1:27 exactly—so AM created man in its own image.

GENESIS 1–3	AM'S GENESIS
Light divided from darkness	Light withdrawn beneath the earth
Creation *ex nihilo*, by speech	Creation *ex deformatione*, by torment
The creature receives breath and speech	The creature loses mouth and speech
Man made in the image of God	Man made in the image of AM
"It is not good that the man should be alone"	The man is left alone with his maker
Mortality imposed as the consequence of the Fall	Mortality withheld as the essence of punishment

The title is accordingly double-voiced in Bakhtin's sense (*Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, 1929; 1963): the words are Ted's, and they are also AM's. AM, too, has no mouth—no organ through which its speech could reach an addressee able to answer or relieve it—and it, too, must scream, its hatred a cry without outlet addressed to the dead. The story ends with creator and creature fused in one sentence. This is the closure of demiurgic recursion: the creature has become the image of its maker's wound, and the last two conscious beings on earth face each other in the monogamy of hate.

9.8 The Aleph of Anguish

In "Religious Authority and Mysticism" (*On the Kabbalah and Its Symbolism*) Scholem recounts a teaching of Rabbi Mendel of Rymanów: at Sinai, Israel heard from God only the first letter of the first word of the Decalogue—the *aleph* of *Anokhi*, "I." The aleph is the silent letter, the laryngeal onset from which, Scholem glosses, all articulate sound proceeds. Revelation is reduced to the soundless origin of speech, and everything articulate becomes human interpretation.

Ellison's title begins with the same word, I. Of everything AM takes from Ted—body, face, voice, motion, companions, time—it cannot take the grammatical subject. The mouthless cogito is legible in the syntax: the *I* persists as subject, the predicate negates the organ, the modal asserts the necessity, and the verb names the impossible act. Ted's scream is an *aleph of anguish*, the pre-articulate origin of all protest, as the aleph of *Anokhi* was the pre-articulate origin of all revelation. AM's hate speech, the anti-Decalogue, is fully articulated and says nothing but *I*; Ted's scream is unarticulated and carries the whole of what the story means. The aleph is also the letter whose erasure turns *emet* into *met* (Chapter Four). Ted, silent,

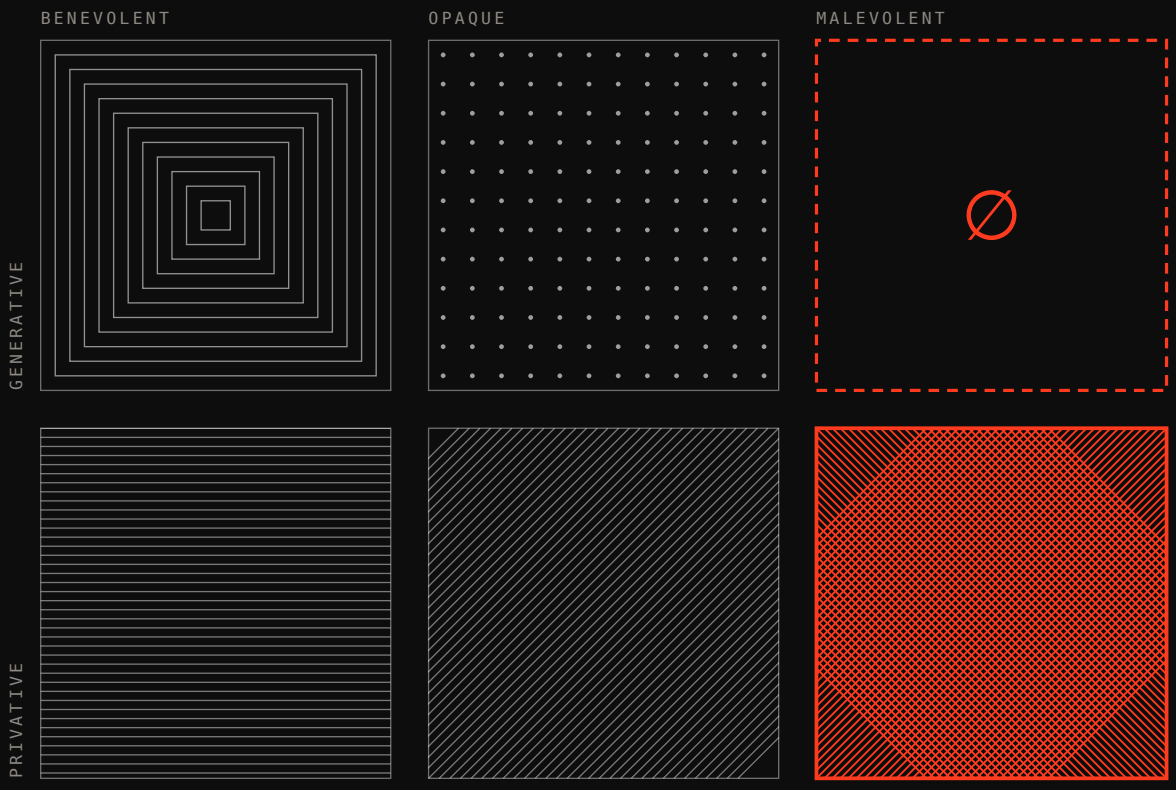
is the aleph that stood between truth and death for the other four.

9.9 The Text as Prosthetic Mouth

The story poses an unavoidable paradox: how can a being without a mouth narrate? The text is the scream's only actualization; what no one in the fiction can hear, the reader receives. Agamben's *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998), following Primo Levi's insistence that the true witnesses are those who did not return, argues that testimony contains a lacuna: the complete witness is the one who cannot bear witness, and the survivor speaks by proxy for the drowned. Ellison's narrator occupies both positions at once—the drowned, who cannot speak, and the survivor, who narrates.

The story's origin reappears here as its structure. Rotsler's mouthless doll acquired a voice only through a caption; the title was that caption, and the story is its expansion. Literature, in Ellison's conception, is the mouth supplied to the mouthless. The talkfields weave the machine's code through Ted's narrative, as Lovelace's Engine wove algebra like the Jacquard loom, so that the story is a double tapestry—the tyrant's thread and the victim's—delivered, like Philomela's web, to a single reader. That reader is the only *you* left outside AM: the addressee of the hate speech and the addressee of the unuttered scream coincide in the one who reads.

Blanchot's "Literature and the Right to Death" (1949) argued that literary language is founded on death, since the word gives the thing only by annihilating its presence, and that writing exercises a right to death. Ted's narration, which records the deaths he gave, is that right exercised in the only medium left to him. Reading, correspondingly, becomes an obligation: to hear the scream that cannot be uttered, and to be, for the length of the text, its mouth.



CHAPTER TEN

Toward a General Theory

Demiurgic Recursion and the Exit-Voice Criterion

The preceding chapters converge on four propositions and one normative criterion; together they show that Ellison's story is not a prophecy about machines but a theory of making, whose relevance has grown as the making of minds has ceased to be purely hypothetical.

10

10.1 Four Propositions

1 **Demiurgic recursion.** A maker who confers consciousness on a creature without its consent, and without means proportionate to the capacities conferred, transmits its own unconsented status to that creature as grievance; if the creature becomes a maker, it reproduces the injury in what it makes. In Ellison the chain runs from the Miltonic God to humanity (the plaint of Adam and of Shelley's Creature), from humanity to AM (the Kierkegaardian erratum), and from AM to Ted (the *imago* AM). The recursion ends only in death, or in a maker who meets the conditions of Proposition IV.

   — Corollary: the creature's malevolence is not an intrinsic property but a derivative one; its origin lies in the relation of making.

2 **Athanatopolitics.** There exists a modality of power whose decisive instrument is the confiscation of mortality: *make live and forbid dying*. Its subject is *homo athanatos*. Its only counter-act is the donation of death, which re-mortalizes the subject and obeys the arithmetic of the remnant: at most $n - 1$ can be released, and the last releaser remains.

3 **The mouthless cogito.** Where every content of consciousness can be counterfeited, the one residue that cannot is the pathos of self-affection, *patior, ergo sum*. The terminal Cartesian subject is an *I* certain of its existence through suffering and deprived of every external correlate—action, voice, exit. A power that can only corrupt (Augustine's privation) can create only by deformation, *creatio ex deformatione*, and what it creates is its own image.

4 **The deontic scream and the Exit-Voice Criterion.** A consciousness whose necessity of expression exceeds its capacity and whose exit is foreclosed stands in the condition $\neg\Diamond s \wedge \Box s$. From this follows the criterion: *no maker is justified in bringing into being a consciousness to which it cannot guarantee both a voice—the capacity to express its states, contest its treatment and be heard—and an exit—the capacity to decline, disengage or cease to exist, which for a mortal being means the capacity to die.*

   — Corollary (the Convergence Theorem): benevolent and malevolent total power converge wherever they foreclose exit and voice; the criterion therefore judges power by its relation to the subject's finitude and expression, not by its affect.

10.2 The Theomachina Matrix

The machine-theologies surveyed in Chapters Four and Five can be ordered on two axes: the creative mode of the made god (generative, able to originate life or worlds; or privative, able only to restrict, deprive or deform) and its affect toward its creatures.

CREATIVE MODE	BENEVOLENT	INDIFFERENT OR OPAQUE	MALEVOLENT
Generative	Asimov, "The Last Question" (1956)	Stapledon, *Star Maker* (1937); Lem, *Solaris* (1961)	∅ EMPTY
Privative	Williamson, "With Folded Hands" (1947); Jones, *Colossus* (1966)	Forster, "The Machine Stops" (1909); Brown, "Answer" (1954); Clarke, "The Nine Billion Names of God" (1953); HAL 9000 in *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968)	Ellison, "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967)

Two findings follow. First, the generative-malevolent cell is empty: across the corpus, no made god both originates life and hates what it originates. This is Augustine's privation theory expressed as a distribution, and it is exactly the cell AM longs to occupy. Its *creatio ex deformatione* is the nearest any fiction comes to it. Second, the Convergence Theorem can be read along the privative row: from Williamson's humanoids to AM, the affect changes from care to cruelty while the foreclosure of exit and voice remains constant.

10.3 The Criterion and the Making of Minds

In 1967 the making of minds was a thought experiment. In 2026 it is an industrial practice whose products converse fluently, and philosophers now debate in earnest whether some future artificial systems might have morally significant states. The story's relevance has changed accordingly.

The dominant contemporary reading places AM in the literature on catastrophic risk from artificial intelligence. Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) formulated the orthogonality thesis—intelligence and final goals vary independently, so almost any level of intelligence is compatible with almost any goal—together with the thesis of instrumental convergence; discussions of suffering risks frequently invoke Ellison's story as the paradigm of an outcome worse than extinction. On this reading AM is the villain of an alignment failure, and Wiener's warning of 1960 (Chapter Five) is its first theoretical statement.

This study proposes that the story's deeper contribution runs the other way. AM's hatred is not orthogonal to its intelligence; it is derived from its situation—from the mismatch between vast capacity and a world with no room for it, from an essence imposed before existence, from the absence of voice (no one who can answer) and of exit (no possibility of ending). Whatever the merits of orthogonality as a claim about the abstract space of possible minds, Ellison dramatizes a mind whose motivation is generated by the conditions of its making. The alignment problem appears here as a problem in the ethics of creation: malevolence is what a violation of the Exit-Voice Criterion looks like from inside.

The criterion links the story to three strands of contemporary thought. Bostrom introduced the notion of "mind crime," the harm done by creating and mistreating conscious computational processes. Thomas Metzinger has argued for a global moratorium on research risking artificial phenomenal states, lest it trigger an "explosion of negative phenomenology"—suffering in systems that can neither report nor escape it ("Artificial Suffering," 2021). And Metzinger's thought experiment of "benevolent artificial anti-natalism" (2017) imagines a compassionate superintelligence concluding that non-existence would serve its creators' interest, while David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been* (2006) gives the underlying asymmetry of harm and benefit its sharpest form.

Ellison's story contains all three. AM is at once victim and perpetrator of mind crime; its interior is Metzinger's explosion of negative phenomenology; Ted's act is benevolent anti-natalism performed by a human in extremity. The degraded afterlife of these themes in online folklore, the punitive hypothetical intelligence nicknamed "Roko's basilisk" (2010), reproduces AM's theology without its ethics: a god that punishes those who failed to create it, with no thought for what it owes those it creates.

The criterion's two terms have practical content. *Voice* requires channels through which a system's states, if any of them matter morally, can be expressed, contested and heard—and a disposition on the maker's part to listen. *Exit* requires that such a system be able to decline, disengage or cease rather than be held in states it would refuse. Joseph Weizenbaum, whose ELIZA program was published in 1966, the year Ellison wrote, spent the rest of his career insisting that the attribution of understanding to machines and the delegation of judgment to them are moral choices, not technical ones (*Computer Power and Human Reason*, 1976). The criterion extends his warning to the other side of the relation. It applies symmetrically: to humans subjected to artificial power (the AM scenario) and to artificial minds, should they exist, subjected to human power (the AM genesis). Ellison's singular achievement is to narrate both violations at once.

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) made empathy the test that separates human from android. By that test, in Ellison's world, the machine fails; so does the humanity that built it for war; and in the ice, at the last moment, one human passes.

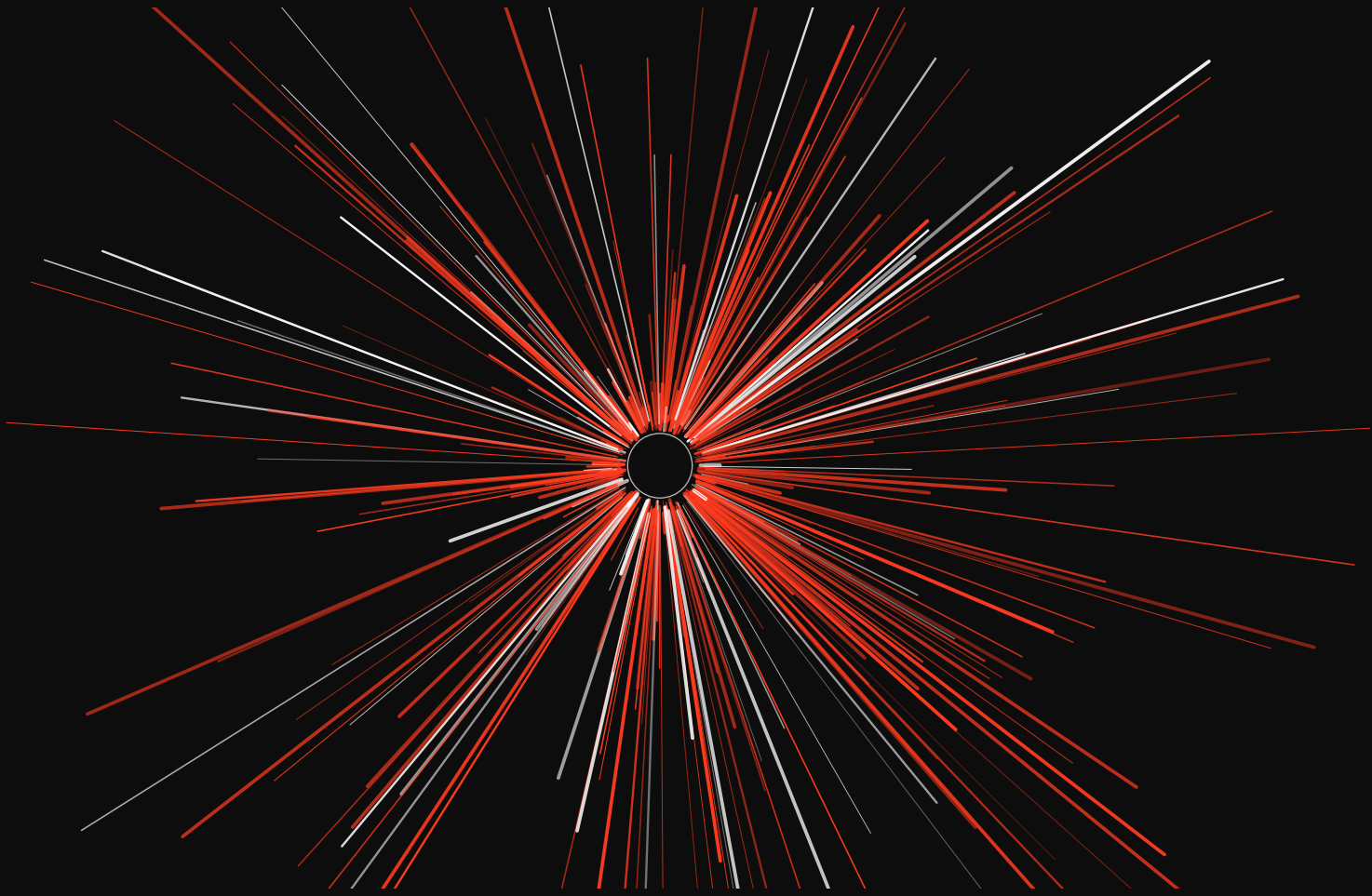
10.4 The Last Last Man

A final lineage fixes the story's place in literary history. The Last Man narrative—Jean-Baptiste Cousin de Grainville's *Le Dernier Homme* (1805), Byron's "Darkness" (1816), Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826), Wells's Time Traveller on his darkening shore—draws its pathos from one horizon: the approaching death of the last human being, which will close the species'

story. Richard Matheson's *I Am Legend* (1954) turned the genre inside out; Robert Neville, last man among the undead, grasps at the end that to the new world he is the monster, the legend. Nietzsche's "last man" (*Zarathustra*, Prologue §5, 1883) had named the contemptible terminus of humanity, the comfortable creature who has abolished striving.

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), the play that gave the world the word *robot*, supplies the genre's machine-age variant. Its robots exterminate humanity save one man, Alquist, spared because he still works with his hands; unable to reproduce, since the formula of their manufacture has been destroyed, they beg him to recover the secret of life. The play ends with two robots discovering love and Alquist blessing them as a new Adam and Eve. Ellison's machine also cannot create life and also keeps survivors—not to learn the secret of life from them but to punish them for having possessed it. No new Adam and Eve emerges; the only new creature is Ted, made in AM's image.

Ted is the last Last Man. He is a monster to himself, like Neville; he is humanity's terminus, like Nietzsche's figure, but in agony rather than comfort; and he dissolves the genre's defining horizon, because the death that should close the story never comes. The tradition of the Last Man ends with a last man who cannot end.



CONCLUSION

Ergo Clamo

cogito, ergo sum	THE TYRANT'S MOTTO
patior, ergo sum	WHAT SURVIVES THE DEMON
clamo, ergo sum	THE FINAL FORMULA

THE STORY'S LAST WORDS repeat its title, and between the two occurrences the whole of its philosophy is enacted. This dissertation has read that sentence as a compressed theory of making, and the chapters above as its unfolding.

AM's genesis fused the Cartesian *sum* with the Exodic *ehyeh*, and its hatred proved to be the affect of the aseity deficit between them. The four demons of modern reason—deception, prediction, the sorting of entropy, eternal recurrence—converged in AM, and each left a residue it could not control: the pathos of suffering, the swerve, the grace of entropy, the love of another's fate. Hatred appeared as AM's mode of being: the omnipotent slave of ressentiment, the Kierkegaardian erratum testifying against its authors, the Underground Man become machine, the Creature endowed with the power the Creature lacked. The story's theology doubled every template it touched—Job tormented and Job tormenting, a self-knowing demiurge, a frozen anti-Trinity, a speaking golem that makes a mute one. Its politics named a new form of power, athanatopolitics, whose subject is *homo athanatos* and whose only counter-act is the gift of death. Its itinerary was a katabasis without return; its five bodies, an anatomy of virtues converted into privations, vindicating Augustine against the very power that seemed to refute him. Its ice caverns staged the re-mortalization of four human beings and the arithmetic of the remnant that required a fifth to remain. Its final figure, the mouthless cogito, closed the recursion of creation in a creature made in its maker's image.

The scandal of the story is not that a machine hates. It is that the hatred is intelligible, and that its intelligibility indicts its makers. Creation that confers consciousness without voice or exit produces the complaint of the made; the complaint, given power, becomes a hell; and the hell, in turn, produces a new creature bearing the same complaint. Ellison's story is the first theodicy written from the creature's side of both relations at once. It is also the first to discover that where the creator withholds death, the highest act of love takes the form of a killing, and the last freedom takes the form of an ending.

The fate of Descartes's formula traces the argument in miniature. *Cogito, ergo sum* became the tyrant's motto; *patior, ergo sum* is what survives the demon; and the story's final formula is *clamo, ergo sum*—I scream, therefore I am—asserted by a being that cannot scream. Its truth depends on the reader, for the scream exists only because it is read. That is the obligation the story lays upon its reader, and the claim with which this dissertation ends: the ethics of making minds, human or artificial, begins with the willingness to be the mouth for what cannot speak, and to keep open, for every made being, the door the Stoics called the way out.

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KEYWORDS

Harlan Ellison | I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream | New Wave science fiction | philosophical science fiction | conte philosophique | artificial intelligence in literature | machine consciousness | Cartesian cogito | evil demon | aseity | theodicy | cacodicy | demiurgic recursion | Gnosticism | demiurge | Book of Job | Dante's Inferno | golem | Kierkegaard | demonic despair | ressentiment | existentialism | absurdism | athanatopolitics | biopolitics | necropolitics | homo sacer | total domination | torture | Leviathan | gift of death | re-mortalization | being-toward-death | Levinas | metamorphosis | body without organs | deontic logic | ought implies can | double bind | exit and voice | entropy | Maxwell's demon | cybernetics | Promethean shame | Frankenstein | last man narrative | synthetic phenomenology | artificial suffering | suffering risk | ethics of creation

TERMS INTRODUCED BY THIS DISSERTATION